A THESIS ON THE WORKS OF MIYAZAKI HAYAO

CONSPIRATIO

Breath, Contamination, and the Unfinished Human in the Works of Miyazaki Hayao

TOWARD A PNEUMATIC HUMANISM



October 2026

Abstract

This dissertation reconstructs the philosophical architecture of the work of Miyazaki Hayao (b. 1941), from *Rupan Sansei: Kariosutoro no shiro* (1979) to *Kimitachi wa dō ikiru ka* (*The Boy and the Heron*, 2023), with sustained attention to the seven-volume manga *Kaze no tani no Naushika* (1982–1994), and on that basis advances a new theoretical position, *conspiratorial humanism*, from the Latin *conspirare*, "to breathe together." Against readings that settle the oeuvre into environmental fable, national nostalgia, or "strong-girl" feminism, it argues that Miyazaki's films and manga are organized by a single, insistently material problematic: the atmosphere—wind, breath, spore, miasma, steam, smoke, and weather—as the medium through which humans, nonhumans, machines, gods, and the dead are bound into a common fate.

Part I establishes a genealogy: a childhood inside the aerial warfare of 1945 and the aircraft industry that sustained it; the Tōei Dōga union, Takahata Isao, and an inherited Marxism later renounced; and decisive encounters with Nakao Sasuke's laurel-forest culture thesis, Amino Yoshihiko's historiography of the margins, Hotta Yoshie's literature of catastrophe, and a Western library running from Homer and Swift through Saint-Exupéry and Valéry to Le Guin. Part II systematizes four tenets: an animism of attention rather than belief; a refusal of the villain grounded in an ontology of contagious violence; an ethics of the hand and of convivial tools; and a constitutively ambivalent love of flight.

Parts III and IV stage two confrontations. With feminist thought—Beauvoir, Young, Cixous, Irigaray, Gilligan, Ruddick, Tronto, Kittay, Plumwood, Merchant, Shiva, Haraway, and Kristeva, read alongside Hiratsuka Raichō, Honda Masuko, Ueno Chizuko, Saitō Tamaki, and Saitō Minako—it argues that Miyazaki's *shōjo* is neither feminist exemplar nor fetish but a philosophical position, defined by exteriority to the productive and reproductive economies, whose redemptive burden the late films progressively return to men. With humanism—from Pico and Montaigne through Kant, Marx, Heidegger, Camus, Weil, and Levinas to Fanon, Wynter, and Braidotti—it argues that Miyazaki practices a *misanthropic humanism* that disqualifies the human as master and requalifies it as participant, culminating in a refusal of purity in its ecological, eugenic, moral, and national forms.

Part V synthesizes these findings. Reading Irigaray's charge that Western metaphysics forgot air alongside Sloterdijk's diagnosis of the twentieth century as the age of atmospheric terror and Yamamoto Shichihei's anatomy of *kūki*, the coercive "air" of Japanese consensus, it argues that Miyazaki opposes to both weaponized and conformist air a third atmosphere, *kaze*, the wind of a shared world, and that his heroines are *anemotropic* subjects who read the wind rather than the room. The dissertation concludes with seven theses of a pneumatic humanism: a humanism whose unit is not the autonomous individual but the shared breath; whose ethic is the metabolization rather than the eradication of contamination; whose form is the respiratory interval (*ma*); and whose political horizon—tested against Fanon's "combat breathing" and Mbembe's universal right to breathe—is the equitable distribution of air.

PRELIMINARIES

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Note on Conventions and Corpus

Japanese personal names appear in Japanese order, surname first (Miyazaki Hayao, Takahata Isao), except for scholars who publish in English under Western order (Kumiko Saito, Shiro Yoshioka). Japanese terms follow modified Hepburn romanization with macrons (*shōjo*, *Tōei*), save for place-names naturalized in English (Tokyo). Films are cited by English title after first mention. Translations from Latin, French, German, classical Chinese, and Japanese are the author's unless otherwise indicated; direct quotation is confined to texts in the public domain, and all other sources, including Miyazaki's own statements, are paraphrased. Citations follow an author–date system. Unless another venue is named, Miyazaki's prose is cited from the two collected volumes *Shuppatsuten* 1979–1996 (1996; trans. *Starting Point*, 2009) and *Orikaeshiten* 1997–2008 (2008; trans. *Turning Point*, 2014).

The primary corpus comprises the twelve features Miyazaki directed, the *Nausicaä* manga, the illustrated tale *Shuna no tabi* (1983), the television series *Mirai shōnen Konan* (1978), and the Ghibli Museum short *Kemushi no Boro* (2018). Screenplays written for other directors (*Mimi o sumaseba*, 1995; *Karigurashi no Arietti*, 2010; *Kokuriko-zaka kara*, 2011) serve as secondary evidence. Miyazaki turned eighty-five in January 2026 and remains active (AceShowbiz, 2026); the corpus is therefore provisional by definition.

English title	Japanese title	Year	Principal source or intertext
Lupin III: The Castle of Cagliostro	*Rupan Sansei: Kariosutoro no shiro*	1979	Monkey Punch's *Lupin III*; Maurice Leblanc, *La Comtesse de Cagliostro*
Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind	*Kaze no tani no Naushika*	1984	Miyazaki's manga; Homer, *Odyssey* VI; *Mushi mezuru himegimi*
Castle in the Sky	*Tenkū no shiro Rapyuta*	1986	Swift, *Gulliver's Travels*, Book III
My Neighbor Totoro	*Tonari no Totoro*	1988	Original; the laurel-forest culture thesis
Kiki's Delivery Service	*Majo no takkyūbin*	1989	Kadono Eiko's novel (1985)
Porco Rosso	*Kurenai no buta*	1992	Miyazaki, *Hikōtei jidai* (1989)
Princess Mononoke	*Mononoke-hime*	1997	Original; Amino Yoshihiko's medieval history
Spirited Away	*Sen to Chihiro no kamikakushi*	2001	Kashiwaba Sachiko, *Kiri no mukō no fushigi na machi* (1975)
Howl's Moving Castle	*Hauru no ugoku shiro*	2004	Diana Wynne Jones's novel (1986)
Ponyo	*Gake no ue no Ponyo*	2008	Andersen, "Den lille Havfrue" (1837)
The Wind Rises	*Kaze tachinu*	2013	Horikoshi Jirō; Hori Tatsuo; Valéry, "Le Cimetière marin"
The Boy and the Heron	*Kimitachi wa dō ikiru ka*	2023	Yoshino Genzaburō's novel (1937)

風

INTRODUCTION

The Problem of the Atmosphere

Miyazaki's first wholly authored feature opens on a respirator. A masked swordsman crosses a village already swallowed by the spores of a toxic forest, and the first human face the film withholds is withheld by a filter. Thirty-nine years later, his most recent feature opens on a siren, a hospital burning in wartime Tokyo, and a boy running through smoke toward a mother he cannot reach. Between these two images lies the most sustained meditation on air in the history of the moving image: gliders and seaplanes, bombers and dirigibles, a cat that is a bus because it is a gust, a bathhouse that runs on steam, a castle that breathes coal smoke, a dying woman's tuberculous cough, and an engineer's beloved and lethal wing. This dissertation contends that the atmosphere is not the setting of Miyazaki's work but its problem, the element in which its ethical, political, theological, and formal commitments are at once posed and tested.

State of the Field

Anglophone scholarship has produced three dominant interpretive paradigms. The *ecological* paradigm, from Mayumi, Solomon, and Chang's early account of consumption and environment in the films (2005) to Gossin's "ecophilosophy" (2015), reads Miyazaki as an environmental moralist. The *national-cultural* paradigm, sharpened by Yoshioka's analysis of nostalgia and "Japaneseness" in *Spirited Away* (2008), situates the films within postwar discourses of loss and identity. The *heroine* paradigm, inaugurated by Napier's account of the *shōjo* as an "enchantment of estrangement" (2005) and contested by Saitō Tamaki's psychoanalysis of the "beautiful fighting girl" (2000; trans. 2011), asks whether Miyazaki's girls emancipate or merely relocate desire. Napier's later *Miyazakiworld* (2018) supplies the indispensable biographical synthesis, and her earlier concept of a "cinema of de-assurance" (2001) remains the most precise description of the films' refusal of consolation. Japanese criticism, notably Kiridōshi Risaku (2001), Murase Manabu (2004), and Inaba Shin'ichirō's reading of the *Nausicaä* manga as a text poised at the critical limit of utopia (1996), has attended more closely to the manga and to Miyazaki's historical thought.

The exception that clarifies the rule is Thomas Lamarre's *The Anime Machine* (2009), which reads Miyazaki through the technical specificity of the animated

image, its layered planes and lateral sliding, and identifies in the films a "technical ethics" of flight opposed to the ballistic vision of modern war. Lamarre comes closest to the present argument, but his object is technology rather than the medium technology moves through. Across all three paradigms, air remains background: the condition of flight, the vehicle of spores, the scenery of wind. The present study proposes to read it as figure.

Research Questions

Four questions organize the inquiry. First, what are the core philosophical commitments of Miyazaki's work, and from which thinkers, texts, and traditions do they derive? Second, how do these commitments stand in relation to the major traditions of feminist thought and of humanism, both Western and Japanese? Third, is there a single generative problem from which these commitments unfold, such that their apparent contradictions, pacifism and the love of warplanes, misanthropy and faith in children, feminism and the idealized girl, become legible as tensions within one structure? Fourth, what new theoretical position emerges when that structure is articulated in its own terms?

Method

The method is constellational, in the sense Benjamin and Adorno gave the term: sources, comparanda, and works are arranged so that each illuminates the others without being reduced to a cause or an instance. Three relations are distinguished throughout. *Genealogy* designates documented influence, established from Miyazaki's own statements, reading lists, and dialogues. *Affinity* designates structural resonance without contact, as between Nausicaä and Barbara McClintock or between the bathhouse contract and Pateman's sexual contract. *Friction* designates comparisons whose value lies in exposing a limit, of the source, of the theory, or of Miyazaki. Close reading attends to animation as a medium, to timing, layering, interval, and the labor of the drawn line, and not merely to narrative. The manga is treated as Miyazaki's philosophical laboratory: written across twelve years in parallel with seven films, it is the site where commitments the films state lyrically are pressed to their logical and ethical extremes.

Thesis

The argument is that Miyazaki's oeuvre constitutes, without naming it, a *conspiratorial humanism*: a humanism in which the human is defined neither by essence (Pico), nor by rational autonomy (Kant), nor by self-making (Sartre), nor by its dissolution into networks (the posthuman), but by co-respiration, by the fact and the ethical demand of breathing together with others who are not oneself and not necessarily human. Three atmospheres contend in the films. The first is *atmoterror*, Sloterdijk's name for the twentieth century's discovery that one may kill by attacking not bodies but the medium bodies live in; Miyazaki was born into it. The second is *kūki*, the "air" that Yamamoto Shichihei identified as the medium of Japanese consensus, an atmosphere that decides without anyone deciding. The third, which the films oppose to both, is *kaze*, the wind of a shared and contaminated world, read rather than obeyed. Miyazaki's heroines, and in the late films his chastened boys and men, are *anemotropic* subjects: they orient themselves by the wind rather than by the room. The etymological hinge of the argument is that *animation* and *animism* share a root with *anima*, breath, cognate with the Greek *anemos*, wind. To animate is to breathe into. Miyazaki's medium, theology, and ethics are therefore one pneumatology.

Structure

Part I (Chapters 1–2) reconstructs Miyazaki's formation and library, identifying the originators of his principal ideas. Part II (Chapters 3–5) systematizes four tenets: animism as attention, the refusal of the villain, the ethics of labor and the convivial tool, and the ambivalence of flight. Part III (Chapters 6–8) places the work in confrontation with feminist theory: the *shōjo* as philosophical position, the ethics of care and the figures of mother and crone, and ecofeminism read through Irontown and the bathhouse contract. Part IV (Chapters 9–10) places it in confrontation with humanism and its critics, and isolates the refusal of purity as the oeuvre's decisive philosophical act. Part V (Chapter 11) articulates conspiratorial humanism in seven theses and tests them against their strongest objections. The Conclusion returns to the imperative that served as the tagline of *Princess Mononoke* and condenses the whole: *Ikiro*, live.

PART I

Genealogies

CHAPTER 1
Fire from the Sky, Rudders for Zeros

CHAPTER 2
The Library and the Laurel Forest

I

01

CHAPTER 1

Fire from the Sky, Rudders for Zeros: Formation, Labor, and the Abandonment of Marx

Miyazaki's philosophical temperament was formed inside four atmospheres he did not choose: the bombed air of 1945, the industrial air of the aircraft firm his family ran, the sickroom air of a tubercular mother, and the poisoned air of high-growth Japan. His later formations, the union, Marxism, and partnership with Takahata Isao, supplied a vocabulary for these experiences that he eventually discarded while retaining their ethical charge.

1.1 Born Under the Bombers

Miyazaki was born in Tokyo on 5 January 1941, eleven months before Pearl Harbor. The family enterprise, Miyazaki Airplane, led by his uncle with his father Katsuji among its directors, manufactured components, rudders among them, for the Mitsubishi A6M, the Zero. Evacuated to Tochigi Prefecture, the four-year-old witnessed the incendiary raid that US Army Air Forces B-29s carried out on Utsunomiya in July 1945, one of the fire raids that burned dozens of Japanese cities that year. Napier's biography (2018) foregrounds a memory Miyazaki has retold in several forms: during the flight from the burning city, the family vehicle did not stop for a neighbor carrying a child who asked to be taken along. Whatever its exact contours, the memory functions in Miyazaki's self-narration as a primal scene of complicity, survival purchased by privilege and by passing someone by.

The scene is worth isolating because the oeuvre returns to it compulsively and inverts it. Nausicaä hauls the wounded onto her glider; Kiki's vocation is to carry; Porco flies Fio out of Milan; the Catbus exists to fetch the lost; Mahito must decide whom to bring back from the tower. Ursula K. Le Guin's "carrier bag theory of fiction" (1986), which displaces the spear-and-hunter narrative in favor of the container, the sling, the gathered and carried thing, describes Miyazaki's narrative ethics with uncanny precision. Its origin, on the evidence of his own account, is a vehicle that did not stop.

The father completed the paradox. Miyazaki has portrayed him with mingled affection and reproach as a modern dandy indifferent to the war's moral meaning and comfortable with its profits. The son inherited both the love of the machines and the shame of their provenance. He would spend a career drawing aircraft with an engineer's tenderness while making films whose central catastrophe is aerial war, a contradiction he named himself and which *The Wind Rises* finally converts into its subject.

1.2 The Sickroom

From roughly 1947 to 1955 Miyazaki's mother, Yoshiko, was incapacitated by spinal tuberculosis, first hospitalized and then nursed at home. Miyazaki has credited her formidable skepticism with his own habit of interrogating received opinion. Tuberculosis is the disease of breath and the privileged illness of modern Japanese letters, from Masaoka Shiki to Hori Tatsuo, and Sontag's *Illness as Metaphor* (1978) anatomized its Western mythology of spiritualized, consumptive beauty. The ill or absent mother recurs through the oeuvre: the hospitalized Yasuko of *Totoro*, the consumptive Naoko of *The Wind Rises*, the mother who burns in the opening of *The Boy and the Heron*. *The Wind Rises* is both fascinated by and critical of the tubercular myth Sontag dismantled, a doubleness examined in Chapter 7.

1.3 Gakushūin, Tōei, and the Union

Miyazaki studied political science and economics at Gakushūin University, graduating in 1963, and belonged to a children's literature research circle. Two conversion experiences preceded his profession. Seeing Tōei's *Hakujaden* (1958), he fell in love with its heroine and concluded, by his own account, that he had been drawing what was fashionable rather than what he loved. Atamanov's Soviet *Snezhnaya koroleva* (*The Snow Queen*, 1957), with Gerda's obdurate devotion, renewed his commitment to the medium. The vocation thus began, twice, with a girl.

He entered Tōei Dōga in 1963 and within a year was serving as chief secretary of its labor union, where he met Takahata Isao. The decisive collaboration was *Taiyō no ōji Horusu no daibōken* (*Horus, Prince of the Sun*, 1968), directed by Takahata with Ōtsuka Yasuo as animation director and Miyazaki in scene design. Produced through an unusually participatory process modeled on union democracy, the film allegorizes a village that survives a demon's assault only through collective labor and solidarity. Its most complex figure is Hilda, a girl divided between service to the demon and human longing, Miyazaki's first ambivalent heroine. The film's commercial failure and the studio's reprisals against its makers taught a second lesson: the conditions of production are themselves a political question.

1.4 The Television Laboratory

The 1970s television work with Takahata, *Arupusu no shōjo Haiji* (1974), *Haha o tazunete sanzenri* (1976), and *Akage no An* (1979), schooled Miyazaki in an ethnographic realism of daily life: the weight of bread, the labor of laundry, the texture of a meal. This attention to the everyday as the site of meaning would become one pole of his mature style. *Mirai shōnen Konan* (1978), adapted from Alexander Key's *The Incredible Tide* (1970), was his first directorial statement. After a catastrophe of electromagnetic weapons, a technocratic city, Industria, confronts an agrarian commune, while the girl Lana communicates across distance and the superweapon is a colossal aircraft, the Gigant. The axis of the oeuvre is already drawn: industrial versus convivial order, the girl as medium of communication, the airplane as instrument of apocalypse. *The Castle of Cagliostro* (1979) followed, a virtuoso caper whose passive teenage princess, Clarisse, became a founding figure of the *rorikon* ("lolicon") boom of the early 1980s, in which adult male fans produced and circulated sexualized drawings of girl characters in self-published *dōjinshi* and in parts of the commercial anime press (Saitō 2000). Miyazaki has criticized animation that makes girls into objects of male fantasy (Miyazaki 2009).

1.5 Marx and After

Miyazaki's political formation belongs to the generation of the 1960 Anpo protests and the union movement, and his early work is legible in a broadly Marxian idiom: history as class struggle, empires as engines of war, labor as the ground of dignity. The *Nausicaä* manga, begun in 1982, initially reads as a historical epic of this kind, with rival empires, dynastic intrigue, and peoples ground between them. Over twelve years of serialization the frame dissolved. Napier (2018) and Miyazaki's interviews from the mid-1990s link the dissolution to the wars of Yugoslavia's breakup, which reached the Dalmatian coast where *Porco Rosso* is set while the film was in production. The Yugoslav People's Army began shelling Dubrovnik in October 1991; from 1992, Bosnian Serb forces besieged Sarajevo and expelled and killed non-Serbs in the campaigns of "ethnic cleansing" later prosecuted by the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia, which also convicted Croat and Bosniak perpetrators. The spectacle of neighbors who had shared a state turning on one another persuaded Miyazaki that history does not progress and that peoples do not learn, and he stated that he had abandoned Marxism. The manga's conclusion in 1994, in which there is no historical subject, no reconciliation, and no purified future, only a decision to go on living, is the formal record of that abandonment.

What survives the renunciation is decisive for this study. Miyazaki discarded teleology, the vanguard, and the conviction that history has a direction; he retained the dignity of labor, the solidarity of the workshop, the critique of commodification, and the suspicion of the state. Studio Ghibli's conversion of animators into salaried employees around 1991 institutionalized the residue. The result may be called a post-Marxian ethics without eschatology. Takahata, temperamentally a critical rationalist and committed to a social realism culminating in *Hotaru no haka* (1988)

and *Heisei tanuki gassen Ponpoko* (1994), maintained a skepticism toward fantasy's power to console that functioned, across five decades, as Miyazaki's internal conscience.

1.6 An Atmospheric Formation

The biographical vectors converge on air. Miyazaki was born under bombers, raised among rudders, and formed beside a sickbed whose disease travels by breath. He came of age in the era of *kōgai*, industrial pollution, when the petrochemical haze of Yokkaichi produced an epidemic of asthma, photochemical smog shut Tokyo schoolyards, and the Diet of 1970 was obliged to legislate the air itself. He turned thirty the following year. Nausicaä's masks, conceived in 1982, have a domestic referent before they have a mythic one. The following chapters show how these atmospheres were transmuted, through reading, into philosophical commitments.

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CHAPTER 2

The Library and the Laurel Forest: Sources, Intertexts, Originators

Miyazaki's ideas have identifiable originators, and five of them did decisive conceptual work: Nakao Sasuke gave him a belonging prior to the nation; Amino Yoshihiko gave him a Japan of margins; Hotta Yoshie, reading Kamo no Chōmei, gave him catastrophe as the ordinary condition of history; Homer and a Heian tale gave him the girl who does not run; and Swift, Saint-Exupéry, and Westall gave him flight as both grace and violence. Around these sit a broader Japanese and Western library and a canon of animation.

2.1 Nakao Sasuke and the Laurel Forest

The botanist Nakao Sasuke's *Saibai shokubutsu to nōkō no kigen* (*Cultivated Plants and the Origins of Agriculture*, 1966) proposed that a single cultural complex extended across the broadleaf evergreen forest belt, *shōyōjurin*, from the southern slopes of the Himalaya through Assam, Yunnan, and southern China to western Japan. Its shared practices included swidden cultivation, the processing of tubers and millets, glutinous foods, fermentation, tea, lacquer, and sericulture. The thesis was elaborated in the volume Ueyama Shunpei edited in 1969 and later by Sasaki Kōmei. Miyazaki has described the encounter as a liberation. It allowed him to locate himself not in a nation-state whose modern history of empire he found unbearable, but in a vegetal and cultural zone that ignores borders, so that he could feel kinship with the forests of Yunnan or Bhutan rather than pride in "Japan" (Miyazaki 2009).

Three consequences follow. Identity becomes ecological rather than national. The forest becomes the matrix of culture rather than its antagonist. And beneath the rice-state of the Yamato court lies an older substrate of forest life to which the films repeatedly return: the camphor tree of *Totoro*, itself a laurel-forest species; the primeval forest of *Mononoke*, modeled on Yakushima; the Himalayan valleys of *Shuna no tabi*. The thesis has been revised by later archaeology, and it carries the risk of a new essentialism, a "deep Japan" of the forest available to *nihonjinron*. Miyazaki's use of it is pointedly anti-national, but the risk does not vanish because the intention is good.

2.2 Amino Yoshihiko and the Margins

The historian Amino Yoshihiko's *Muen, kugai, raku* (1978) argued that medieval Japan contained *muen* spaces, literally "unbound," in markets, temples, roads, rivers, and mountains, where ties of lordship and kinship were suspended and where refuge was possible. His work on *hinōgyōmin*, the non-agricultural peoples, smiths, itinerant artisans, sea-people, entertainers, merchants, women traders, and outcasts, dismantled the image of Japan as a homogeneous nation of rice-growing peasants beneath the emperor. *Princess Mononoke*, set in the Muromachi period, is an Aminoesque film. Its center is not samurai and peasants but Irontown, a *muen*-like enclave of ironworkers, women bought out of brothels, and lepers; its hero is an Emishi, from a people beyond Yamato; its imperial power appears only as a writ carried by a monk-mercenary. Miyazaki discussed the film with Amino in a published dialogue. Amino gave him a past in which Japan was plural, mobile, and unfinished, and therefore a past from which a different future could be imagined.

2.3 Hotta Yoshie, Kamo no Chōmei, and the Literature of Catastrophe

Hotta Yoshie, novelist, essayist, and internationalist, read Kamo no Chōmei's *Hōjōki* (1212) amid the ashes of Tokyo after the raid of 9–10 March 1945, in which US Army Air Forces B-29s burned the city's eastern wards and killed roughly a hundred thousand people. He found in Chōmei's catalogue of urban fire, whirlwind, famine, and earthquake an exact anticipation of his own experience; *Hōjōki shiki* (1971) is the record. Chōmei's opening sentence gives the Buddhist metaphysics of impermanence, *mujō*, its canonical image: the flowing river never ceases, and yet its water is never the same water. Among his disasters is the great whirlwind of 1180, which tore houses from the capital like leaves: wind as catastrophe, eight centuries before the bombers. Miyazaki regarded Hotta as a mentor in historical thinking, joined him and Shiba Ryōtarō in the trialogue *Jidai no fūon* (1992), whose title means "the wind-sound of the age," and reportedly long contemplated animating *Hōjōki shiki*. Hotta's four-volume study of Goya supplied a model of the artist as witness to the disasters of war.

Three lessons pass from Chōmei through Hotta to Miyazaki. Catastrophe is the ordinary condition of history rather than its exception. Lucidity about impermanence need not issue in resignation. And the first ethical act is to see. The earthquake sequence of *The Wind Rises*, in which the Kantō plain ripples like a lung before the city burns and a wind carries the fire, is a Chōmeian tableau rendered in the twentieth century's materials.

2.4 The Japanese Library

Yanagita Kunio's *Tōno monogatari* (1910) and *Yama no jinsei* (1926), with its accounts of children *kamikakushi*, hidden away by gods in the mountains, supply the folkloric grammar of *Spirited Away*'s title. Orikuchi Shinobu's *marebito*, the visiting deity from beyond who arrives, is received, and departs, describes Totoro, the Forest Spirit, Ponyo, and No-Face alike. Miyazawa Kenji's "Chūmon no ōi ryōriten" ("The Restaurant of Many Orders," 1924), in which two hunters obey a restaurant's escalating instructions only to discover that they are being prepared as the meal, is the closest Japanese affinity for the parents who eat the gods' food and become pigs fattened for slaughter.

The twentieth-century novel enters through four doors. Sōsuke of *Ponyo* is named for the protagonist of Natsume Sōseki's *Mon* (1910), read while Miyazaki stayed in Tomonoura. Hori Tatsuo's *Kaze tachinu* (1936–1938), a requiem for a fiancée who died of tuberculosis, gives *The Wind Rises* its title, its heroine's name, and its epigraph from Valéry; Thomas Mann's *Der Zauberberg* (1924) gives it a German named Castorp. Yoshino Genzaburō's *Kimitachi wa dō ikiru ka* (1937), a humanist novel of moral education written under militarism, in which an uncle's notebooks teach a boy to see himself as one particle in a network of production and to face his own cowardice, gives *The Boy and the Heron* its title and places the book in Mahito's hands as his dead mother's gift. Kashiwaba Sachiko's *Kiri no mukō no fushigi na machi* (1975) and Kadono Eiko's *Majo no takkyūbin* (1985) supplied the foundations of *Spirited Away* and *Kiki*. Finally, the late-Heian tale "Mushi mezuru himegimi" ("The Lady Who Loved Insects"), whose heroine keeps caterpillars because she values the real over appearances and refuses to blacken her teeth or pluck her eyebrows as her rank requires, is the oldest stratum of Nausicaä: a girl who refuses both the disgust and the femininity her world prescribes.

2.5 The Western Library

Miyazaki met Homer's Nausicaa, by his own account, through the entry in a Japanese translation of Bernard Evslin's dictionary of Greek mythology, which portrayed her as a girl who loved nature and music more than suitors. In *Odyssey* VI the Phaeacian princess goes to the river-mouth to wash clothes, and when the shipwrecked Odysseus emerges naked and brine-crusted from the thicket, her companions scatter while she alone stands her ground and offers him clothing and the road to the city. Hospitality toward the frightening stranger, the girl who does not run from the monster, is the ethical seed of the *Nausicaä* project.

Swift's *Gulliver's Travels* (1726) supplies Laputa: a flying island governed by mathematicians so abstracted that servants must strike them with bladders to recall them to sense, and whose king disciplines rebellious towns below by hovering to deprive them of sun and rain, by pelting them with stones, or by descending to crush them. Swift's satire is the first literary image of air power as sovereignty, and Miyazaki's *Castle in the Sky* inherits both the critique of abstraction and the vertical

tyranny, adding a robot that has become a gardener and a tree whose roots outlast the weapon.

Antoine de Saint-Exupéry's *Vol de nuit* (1931) and *Terre des hommes* (1939) offer an aviator's humanism: the airmail pilot as a figure of duty and comradeship, and the earth seen from the air as the "land of men." Miyazaki contributed commentary to a Japanese edition of the latter, and his reading holds the aviator's nobility and the airplane's bloodied history in the same hand; Kiki's deliveries descend from Saint-Exupéry's mailbags. Ursula K. Le Guin's Earthsea (from 1968), which Le Guin later recalled Miyazaki had kept close for decades, shaped *Shuna no tabi* and much else; her novella *The Word for World Is Forest* (1972) is *Mononoke*'s closest Western affinity. Robert Westall's war fiction, *The Machine Gunners* (1975) and the bomber-crew story "Blackham's Wimpey," gave Miyazaki the moral horror of aerial war seen from inside the machine; he paid homage with an illustrated pilgrimage to Westall's Tynemouth for a Japanese edition. Miyazaki's *Hon e no tobira* (2011), a commentary on fifty Iwanami children's books, maps the wider canon: Philippa Pearce, Mary Norton, Arthur Ransome, Andersen. Diana Wynne Jones's *Howl's Moving Castle* (1986) supplied a heroine cursed with age.

A penumbra of further sources is visible on the screen. The procession of dead airmen ascending into a river of sky in *Porco Rosso* recalls Roald Dahl's "They Shall Not Grow Old" (1946); the song Gina sings is "Le Temps des cerises" (1866), anthem of the Paris Commune; Ponyo's true name is Brünnhilde, and Hisaishi Joe's score parodies Wagner's Valkyries; Millais's *Ophelia* (1851–1852), seen at Tate Britain, haunted the preparation of *Ponyo*; Böcklin's *Die Toteninsel* (1880–1886) is quoted in the island tomb of *The Boy and the Heron*.

2.6 The Animation Library

Beyond *Hakujaden* and Atamanov's *Snow Queen*, the decisive animated sources are Paul Grimault and Jacques Prévert's *La Bergère et le Ramoneur* (1952), later *Le Roi et l'Oiseau* (1980), whose vertical palace, tyrant, and giant robot left their mark on *Cagliostro* and *Laputa* (Takahata would translate Prévert's *Paroles* into Japanese), and the Fleischer studio's *The Mechanical Monsters* (1941). Jean Giraud, Moebius, was an interlocutor of mutual admiration; he named his daughter Nausicaa, and the two shared an exhibition at the Musée de la Monnaie in Paris in 2004–2005.

2.7 Five Convergences

Read together, the library converges on five propositions that Part II will systematize. Belonging precedes and exceeds the nation. The margin is where history is made and remembered. Catastrophe is ordinary, and lucidity about it is an ethical achievement. The girl who does not run from the monster models a hospitality that is also an epistemology. And flight is both grace and violence, never one without the other. Each proposition is, at bottom, a claim about a medium shared with others: forest, margin, ruin, encounter, sky.

PART II

Tenets

CHAPTER 3
The Neighborly Sacred

CHAPTER 4
The Curse Without a Villain

CHAPTER 5
The Hand and the Wing

II

03

CHAPTER 3

The Neighborly Sacred: Animism as a Discipline of Attention

Miyazaki's animism is not the belief that spirits exist but a discipline of attention that treats the world as populated by addressable others. Its theological signature is adjacency rather than transcendence, and its aesthetic correlate is the animator's labor of drawing everything, wind included, as though it breathed.

3.1 Not a Religion

Miyazaki disclaims membership in any religion while professing a feeling for the sanctity of certain places, groves and springs one ought to keep clean because something is present there (Miyazaki 2009). The Shinto *kami* that populate his films are not transcendent creators but immanent, local, and plural presences, the *yaoyorozu no kami* or "eight million gods," marked by a rope of rice straw, received at festivals, and offended by pollution: the rope around the camphor in *Totoro*, the *kodama* of *Mononoke*, the radish spirit and river gods of *Spirited Away*, the blind boar-god Okkoto, the sea-goddess Granmamare. Yet Miyazaki secularizes as he sacralizes. His gods are exhausted, polluted, and displaced; the clientele of the bathhouse come to recuperate from human neglect. They are not objects of worship but neighbors in need.

3.2 An Ontology of Adjacency

The title of *My Neighbor Totoro* states a theology: *tonari*, beside. The sacred lives next door. When the father bows before the camphor and thanks it for watching over his daughter, remarking that trees and people were once friends, the gesture is a liturgy of neighborliness rather than worship. Martin Buber's *Ich und Du* (1923) offers the closest philosophical gloss. One may contemplate a tree as an image, a process, a species, or a set of laws; but it can also happen, through will and grace together, that one is drawn into relation with it, and then it ceases to be an It. *Totoro* is the cinematic phenomenology of Buber's tree.

Watsuji Tetsurō's ethics supplies the Japanese counterpart. Reading the compound *ningen*, human being, as "the between of persons," Watsuji located the self in *aidagara*, betweenness, so that a person exists only in and as relation (Watsuji

1937). Miyazaki extends the between beyond the human: an *aidagara* of trees, soot sprites, cats, and gods. The *kami* is not a substance hidden behind the tree but the tree as addressed. The ontology is relational before it is substantial, and its ethical form is courtesy.

3.3 The New Animism

Anthropology has relocated animism from "primitive belief" to relational ontology, and Miyazaki's films anticipate the relocation. Nurit Bird-David (1999) recast animism as a relational epistemology, knowing by relating rather than by abstracting. Graham Harvey (2005) defined it as inhabiting a world full of persons, only some of whom are human. Tim Ingold (2006) argued that animism is not a belief imposed on an inert world but a way of being alive to a world in continuous birth, a heightened sensitivity and responsiveness. Philippe Descola's *Par-delà nature et culture* (2005) distinguished four ontologies, among them animism, which posits shared interiority across different bodies, and naturalism, the modern West's inverse, which posits shared physicality across different interiorities. Miyazaki's films stage naturalism's intrusion into animist worlds, and their protagonists are frequently double agents: the archaeologist father who believes his daughters, the princess who runs a laboratory of toxic spores and also hears the Ohmu.

Eduardo Viveiros de Castro's perspectivism (1998; 2009) is more exact still. In many Amerindian cosmologies every species sees itself as human and sees its food as human food; what humans see as blood, the jaguar sees as manioc beer. *Spirited Away* is a perspectivist film. What the family sees as an abandoned theme park is, to the gods, a resort; what the parents see as an unattended feast is the gods' own provision, and eating it transforms their bodies; Chihiro begins to fade, losing her visibility in the spirit world, until Haku makes her eat a berry of that world. To see and be seen depends on what one eats, which is to say on the body one comes to have. Jane Bennett's account of "thing-power" in *Vibrant Matter* (2010) completes the picture at the level of objects: Calcifer, the walking castle, the scarecrow, the soot sprites, and the Catbus are vibrant matter. The *mononoke* of the 1997 title are, literally, the *ke* of things, and classical orthography sometimes writes that *ke* with the graph for vapor or breath.

3.4 Satoyama, Not Wilderness

Miyazaki's sacred is not wilderness. *Totoro*'s world is *satoyama*, the managed mosaic of coppice woodland, paddy, and hamlet that is a second nature sustained by human labor, the same landscape whose abandonment and revival Anna Tsing traces in *The Mushroom at the End of the World* (2015). The Totoro no Furusato Foundation, established in 1990 with Miyazaki's support, conserves the Sayama Hills that inspired the film. This distinguishes him from deep ecology's cult of untouched nature and from the American sublime: the sacred is co-produced by forest and farmer. The film's 1950s setting is nonetheless nostalgic, a countryside before television, before pollution, before high growth, of the kind the Shōwa-nostalgia industry would later commodify. Totoro's world brackets the occupation and the Korean War procurement boom that financed Japan's recovery. The film's implicit defense is phenomenological rather than historical: it does not claim the world was so, only that a child's attention could make it so.

3.5 Ma: The Interval Where Attention Happens

In a 2002 conversation with Roger Ebert, Miyazaki explained *ma* by clapping his hands: the time between the claps is *ma*, an emptiness that is not empty, without which a film is only busyness (Ebert 2002). The bus-stop sequence of *Totoro*, rain falling, drops gathering on leaves and detonating on Totoro's umbrella while nothing happens and everything is noticed, and the Sea Railway of *Spirited Away*, where Chihiro and No-Face ride in silence past drowned platforms and translucent commuters, are *ma* as structure. Simone Weil defined attention as the suspension of thought, held empty and available, so that the object can enter it, and called it the rarest and purest form of generosity. Iris Murdoch's "unselfing" (1970) has the same structure: the brooding ego vanishes at the sight of a kestrel hovering in the wind. Miyazaki's *ma* is a technique for producing such attention in an audience, an animated liturgy of noticing.

3.6 Animation as Insufflation

The deepest unity of Miyazaki's medium and his theology is etymological. Latin *anima*, breath and soul, gives both *animation* and *animism*, and is cognate with Greek *anemos*, wind. The founding myth of animation is a god breathing into clay; Pygmalion's statue is its Ovidian variant. Lamarre (2009) shows that the animated image produces its sense of movement less by thrusting a camera into depth than by sliding layers laterally against one another, so that the world becomes a set of planes in relative motion. Miyazaki's studio paints its backgrounds with the care given to characters, and animates the medium itself: wind combing a paddy into silver waves, the Catbus legible only as a wake through the grass. To animate wind is to make the invisible medium a presence. Miyazaki's animism is therefore his theory of animation, and his theory of animation is a pneumatology. The animator, drawing a gust through rice, performs in miniature the act the films ask of their viewers: to attend to what everyone breathes and no one sees until it becomes a someone.

04

CHAPTER 4

The Curse Without a Villain: Hatred, Contagion, and the Ethics of Ambivalence

Miyazaki's refusal of the villain is not moral relativism but an ontology of violence. Hatred in his work is a substance that passes between bodies like a contagion or a miasma; the ethical task is therefore not to destroy the evil one but to interrupt transmission.

4.1 The Disappearance of the Villain

The early works still have villains: Count Cagliostro, the technocrat Lepka of *Conan*, Muska of *Laputa*. From *Totoro*, which has no antagonist at all, the type dissolves. Kushana is wounded, ambitious, and finally an ally; Dola is a pirate who becomes a mother; Curtis is vain but decent; Eboshi liberates and destroys; Yubaba tyrannizes and dotes; the Witch of the Waste, curser and cursed, ends as a dependent; Fujimoto is a misanthropic guardian; the great-uncle of *The Boy and the Heron* is a visionary who has failed. Miyazaki has repeatedly argued that the world is too complex for clean villainy, since people act for reasons (Miyazaki 2014). Napier's "cinema of de-assurance" (2001) names the structural effect: the films withhold the consolations of genre, clear evil, decisive victory, and restoration, and replace the climax of annihilation with retreat, reconciliation, or uneasy coexistence.

4.2 Tatari: Hatred as Substance

Princess Mononoke opens with the boar-god Nago, wounded by an iron ball from Irontown's guns, transformed into a *tatarigami*, a curse-god, his body a seething mass of hand-drawn tendrils. Ashitaka kills him and is contaminated; the curse climbs his arm and will kill him; the village's wise woman sends him west to see with *kumorinaki manako*, an unclouded eye. In Japanese religious history *tatari* designates the affliction visited by a wronged or angered spirit, and the classical state managed it by enshrining the vengeful dead. Miyazaki's innovation is to visualize *tatari* as quasi-material, hatred become stuff and transmitted by contact, and to give it an ecological genealogy. Forest is cut for charcoal; iron sand is smelted; guns are cast; a god is wounded; a curse is born; a prince's arm rots. Hatred is the forest's pollution returned. The curse is a metabolic by-product of the extractive economy.

4.3 Mimetic Contagion and the Failed Sacrifice

René Girard's *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) argued that violence is mimetic and contagious, that communities avert the escalating reciprocity of a "sacrificial crisis" by uniting against a scapegoat whose death restores peace, and that the sacred is the misrecognized memory of that founding murder. *Mononoke* is an anatomy of a sacrificial crisis. Irontown, the samurai of Lord Asano, the imperial hunters, boars, wolves, and apes are locked in mimetic escalation; the boars' suicidal charge and Okkoto's corruption show rage becoming *tatari*. The decapitation of the Forest Spirit is the sacrifice par excellence, undertaken by the Emperor's agent, the hunters, and Eboshi to obtain immortality and land. But the sacrifice fails. The headless god becomes a tide of death that withers whatever it touches; no peace issues from the victim. Only restitution, the head carried back and offered by human hands, ends the catastrophe.

The film thereby refuses the sacrificial logic Girard placed at the root of the sacred: there is no peace purchased through a victim. The film of *Nausicaä* had risked precisely that logic, with a heroine who dies before a stampede and is resurrected as the prophesied "one clothed in blue," and Miyazaki is reported to have regarded its quasi-messianic climax with unease. The manga, as Chapter 10 shows, dismantles the prophecy; *Mononoke* converts the dismantling into structure.

4.4 Force and the Cursed Arm

Simone Weil's essay on the *Iliad* (1940–1941) defines force as that which turns whoever is subjected to it into a thing, and shows that it petrifies the one who wields it as surely as the one it strikes. Miyazaki literalizes the insight. The curse on Ashitaka's arm confers superhuman strength; his arrows sever heads and limbs; the more the arm kills, the faster it consumes him. To wield force is to be possessed by it. Howl's transformations into a winged monster to harass the war's aircraft threaten to make him unable to return to human form; Porco, by the code of his dogfights, shoots engines rather than pilots. The most precise image of interruption comes early. Enraged by her father's murder, Nausicaä kills Tolmekian soldiers, and Lord Yupa halts her by taking her blade through his own forearm. The violence is absorbed rather than returned, held in one body rather than passed to another. Yupa's arm is the oeuvre's model of ethical action under force.

4.5 Deus sive Natura: The Indifferent God

The Forest Spirit gives and takes life; flowers bloom and die beneath its hooves; it heals Ashitaka's gunshot wound but not his curse; it is indifferent to human moral categories. Spinoza's *Ethica* (1677) provides the exact concept. *Deus sive Natura* acts from necessity rather than purpose; good and evil name what increases or diminishes a body's power of acting; and every thing, insofar as it is in itself, strives to persevere in its being (III, prop. 6), the *conatus*. Thales, as Aristotle reports, held that all things are full of gods, a pre-Socratic sentence that the Shinto *yaoyorozu* would recognize. Miyazaki's planning memo for *Mononoke* framed its conflict as one that admits no happy ending between raging gods and humans, only the possibility of living on (Miyazaki 2014). The ethical correlate of a god beyond good and evil is not resignation but *conatus* joined to care: the film's tagline, *Ikiro*, is a Spinozist imperative, live, addressed to all things at once.

4.6 Eyes Unclouded

Kumorinaki manako names an epistemology, and its metaphor is atmospheric: *kumori* is haze, cloud, an obscured sky. Hatred is weather in the eye. To see with unclouded eyes is not to be neutral, since Ashitaka takes the side of life against every faction that would destroy it, but to refuse to let hatred's haze stand between perceiver and world. Iris Murdoch (1970) called the corresponding moral achievement "unselfing," the clearing of the ego's fog. *The Boy and the Heron* completes the arc by turning it inward. After a fight with schoolboys, Mahito strikes his own head with a stone and lets the adults believe he was assaulted; later, offered the stewardship of a world, he declines by naming the scar as the mark of his own malice. This is the anti-scapegoat gesture, locating the origin of violence in oneself rather than in an enemy. Ashitaka's curse came from outside; Mahito's comes from within. The late Miyazaki moves from the contamination one suffers to the contamination one is.

4.7 Toward a Respiratory Ethics of Violence

Violence in Miyazaki is atmospheric. It spreads like a miasma, clouds the eye like haze, and passes by contact like breath. The ethical repertoire the films assemble is a repertoire of interruption: Yupa's arm, Ashitaka's restitution, Chihiro's refusal of No-Face's gold, Mahito's confession. Part V will formalize it as a respiratory ethics whose first maxim is simple and severe: one does not exhale the poison one has inhaled.

05

CHAPTER 5

The Hand and the Wing: Labor, Conviviality, and the Cursed Dream of Flight

Miyazaki holds the two vectors of *homo faber*, the working hand and the flying machine, to a single criterion: scale. Labor and technology are goods while they remain convivial, sized to the body and responsive to their medium; they become curses at the threshold where tools begin to use their users and the sky becomes a weapon.

5.1 Work as Formation

Work is the oeuvre's principal medium of moral education. Miyazaki framed *Kiki's Delivery Service* as a film about young women who leave home to work in cities and must negotiate independence and dependence at once (Miyazaki 2009). Kiki's crisis, the loss of her power to fly, is a crisis of vocation, and the counsel of Ursula, the painter in the forest who has suffered the same block, is that the gift, a witch's blood or a painter's or a baker's, is not possessed but practiced, and can be strangled by striving. Chihiro passes from a limp, clinging child to a competent worker by scrubbing the great tub under Lin's tutelage; work restores the self the contract erased. Sophie cleans Howl's castle and thereby asserts a presence in a household that had no place for her. In Depression-era Milan, with the men gone to find work, the Piccolo firm rebuilds Porco's aircraft with grandmothers, mothers, and daughters, and Fio, seventeen, designs it. In Irontown the women pump the great foot-bellows of the *tatara* furnace in shifts, singing, bawdy, proud, and free; their labor literally breathes for the fire.

5.2 Alienation and the Name

In the *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts* of 1844, Marx describes alienated labor as estrangement from the product, from the activity, from other humans, and from species-being, the free and conscious life-activity that makes a human human. *Spirited Away* dramatizes alienation as the loss of a name. Yubaba's contract converts Chihiro into Sen by subtracting characters from her name; the worker becomes a function. Haku has forgotten his name and is enslaved by it; to remember is to recover species-being. The bathhouse is a total institution of service labor, with stratified staff, wages in gold, and a proprietor who counts. No-Face's gold, which turns to dirt, is the counterfeit form of value. Yet the film does not reject labor: Chihiro's dignity comes through work, not by escaping it. Miyazaki distinguishes the labor contract, an instrument of alienation, from labor practice, a medium of formation.

Simone Weil, after a year on factory floors (1934–1935), described the affliction of piecework as the destruction of attention by the machine's tempo, and imagined a work whose rhythm would leave room for thought. William Morris's "Useful Work versus Useless Toil" (1884) defined worthy work by three hopes: of rest, of product, and of pleasure in the work itself. Miyazaki's fantasy settings are Morrisian workshops: the bakery, the hat shop, the aircraft works, the boiler room, the forge.

5.3 The Ethics of the Hand

Miyazaki's commitment to hand-drawn animation is an ethics rather than a nostalgia. Ghibli adopted digital ink, paint, and compositing from the late 1990s without displacing the drawn line, and *Ponyo* returned conspicuously to hand-drawn effects animation. In a 2016 documentary (Arakawa 2016), shown a demonstration of machine-learned motion that animated a grotesque crawling figure, Miyazaki recalled a friend with a disability for whom every movement costs effort and called the demonstration an insult to life itself. The objection was not to computation as such but to motion without a body that knows what moving costs, animation that has never breathed. On 25 March 2025 OpenAI added image generation to its GPT-4o model, and within days a viral wave of "Ghibli-style" conversions of photographs followed. On 27 March the official White House account on X joined it, posting a Ghibli-style rendering of an immigration arrest: a woman, previously deported after a drug-trafficking conviction, weeping as an Immigration and Customs Enforcement officer handcuffs her. The post drew wide criticism, and Miyazaki's 2016 remark circulated again in response (Reason, 28 March 2025). The episode crystallized the underlying dispute: whether a style is a set of transferable visual features or the sediment of a practice, of hands, hours, and attention. It also demonstrated the converse of the problem examined in Section 5.5: a style formed as a discipline of attention could, once detached from its practice, be applied within days to any subject at all, including an act of state enforcement. The reading developed here implies that Miyazaki's films answer the second way: a style is labor's breath made visible. Tim Ingold's account of making as *correspondence* (2013), the maker following the grain of materials rather than imposing form on passive matter, gives the position its anthropology.

5.4 Conviviality

Ivan Illich's *Tools for Conviviality* (1973) distinguished convivial tools, which enlarge each person's competence, control, and initiative, from industrial tools, which beyond certain thresholds establish a "radical monopoly" and render people dependent; *Energy and Equity* (1974) argued that beyond a threshold of speed, transport manufactures inequality, and offered the bicycle as the paradigm of a convivial machine. Nausicaä's Mehve, a jet-assisted glider light enough to carry on one's back and dependent on reading the wind, is the convivial aircraft par excellence. Its kin are the windmills of the Valley, Kiki's broom, Tombo's pedal-powered flyer, the dragonfly-winged Flaptors of Dola's pirates, and Porco's single-seat flying boat. Against them stand the God Warrior, the Tolmekian and Pejite airships, the military dreadnought of *Laputa*, Howl's war fleets, the Gigant of *Conan*, and the bombers that fill Jirō's dreams.

The threshold Illich theorized is the threshold Miyazaki dramatizes: the moment a machine ceases to extend the body's relation to air and begins to dominate the air and those beneath it. Saitō Kōhei's "degrowth communism" (2020; 2023), which rereads the late Marx as an ecological thinker hostile to productivism, gives the

problem a contemporary Marxian idiom. The Valley of the Wind, a self-limiting, wind-powered community of a few hundred, and Irontown, whose emancipatory production devours a forest, stage the degrowth problem two decades before its theorization.

5.5 The Cursed Dream

Miyazaki's love of aircraft is lifelong, recorded in notebooks of military machinery and serialized manga for a modelers' magazine. *The Wind Rises* is its autocritique. Horikoshi Jirō dreams only of beautiful aircraft and designs the Zero. Caproni, his dream-mentor, tells him that airplanes are beautiful but cursed dreams that the sky swallows, and asks whether he would prefer a world with pyramids or without, the pyramids standing for beauty raised by coerced labor; Jirō chooses the pyramids. The pyramid is less allegorical than it looks. In 1944 Mitsubishi's aircraft works in Nagoya, the company and city of Jirō's career, put Korean girls to work without pay, teenagers recruited into the "Women's Volunteer Labor Corps" on false promises of wages and schooling. In 2018 the Supreme Court of Korea ordered Mitsubishi Heavy Industries to compensate several of them, a ruling that Japan's government and the company rejected as contrary to the 1965 settlement between the two states (Korea Times, 29 November 2018). Jirō's colleague Honjō computes the cost of a single aircraft against the poverty of the country; Jirō offers sponge cake to hungry children, who flee, and Honjō calls the gesture hypocrisy. The film is structured by Jirō's aesthetic innocence, his absorption in the curve of a mackerel bone that becomes a gull wing, and it shows that such absorption is the form complicity takes in a society organized for war.

Heidegger's "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954) describes the essence of modern technology as *Gestell*, an enframing that challenges nature to stand ready as *Bestand*, standing-reserve: the Rhine dammed into a power plant, the airliner on the runway as a reserve of transport. The Zero is the beautiful wing enframed. Miyazaki's achievement is to refuse both available simplifications, the engineer's claim that beauty is innocent and the moralist's claim that it is merely ideology, and to make a film in which the wing is at once a genuine beauty and a genuine curse.

5.6 Ballistic and Lateral Vision

Paul Virilio's *Guerre et cinéma* (1984) traced the fusion of weapon and eye in aerial reconnaissance and the camera-gun. Lamarre (2009) contrasts *cinematism*, the ballistic thrust of perception into depth, with *animetism*, the lateral sliding of layered planes, a floating perception that does not target. Miyazaki's flights are characteristically lateral: Kiki skimming parallel to the sea, Nausicaä riding layers of air above the toxic canopy. Muska, in *Laputa*'s throne room, gazing down through a transparent floor and exulting that the people below look like rubbish, incarnates the ballistic view from above, what Donna Haraway (1988) called the "god trick" of seeing everything from nowhere. Swift had already shown that view to be a sovereignty. The moral axis of flight is the axis of vision: the lateral gaze that dwells among layers against the vertical gaze that targets.

5.7 Synthesis

The hand and the wing are judged by one measure: whether they remain in correspondence with a medium, paper, iron, or air, and with other bodies, or whether they abstract themselves into domination. Below the threshold, labor forms persons and flight forms relations; above it, labor alienates and flight bombs. Miyazaki's notorious ambivalence about machines is not confusion but the precise location of this threshold, which he refuses to place, once and for all, outside himself.

PART III

The Feminist Problematic

CHAPTER 6
The Shōjo as Philosophical Position

CHAPTER 7
Mothers, Crones, and the Labor of Care

CHAPTER 8
Ecofeminism and Its Discontents

III

06

CHAPTER 6

The Shōjo as Philosophical Position

The Miyazakian *shōjo* is best understood neither as a feminist role model nor as an object of desire but as a philosophical position: a subject constituted by exteriority to the productive and reproductive economies, from which the world can be perceived otherwise. The position carries a redemptive burden that feminist theory rightly suspects, and the late films begin to return that burden to men.

6.1 Why Girls?

Miyazaki has given two kinds of reasons. A girl protagonist releases a story from the conventions of the male action hero, whose plot turns on conquest; and *Spirited Away* was made for ten-year-old girls whom the culture addressed chiefly as consumers of romance (Miyazaki 2014). The genealogy runs from Bai-Niang of *Hakujaden*, Gerda of *The Snow Queen*, Hilda of *Horus*, Lana of *Conan*, and the passive Clarisse of *Cagliostro* to Nausicaä in 1982, the turning point at which the girl ceases to be the prize and becomes the agent. Thereafter the gallery is various: a princess who is scientist, warrior, and diplomat; an heir who renounces a throne in the sky; two sisters bearing an adult household; a courier; an engineer; a feral avenger; a laborer; a young woman cursed into old age; a fish who wants to be a girl.

6.2 Beauvoir's Young Girl and the Femme-Enfant

In the chapter of *Le Deuxième Sexe* (1949) devoted to the young girl, Beauvoir describes puberty as the moment the girl learns to renounce the sovereign use of her body, to stop climbing trees, fighting, and roaming, and to convert her transcendence into waiting and her body into an object for others. Miyazaki's heroines form a counter-archive of the girl who does not renounce: they climb, run, fight, and fly. But Beauvoir's analysis of André Breton in the book's section on myths exposes the trap. Breton's *femme-enfant*, the woman-child who mediates poetry and salvation for man, possesses every virtue except that of being a subject for herself. Sophie restoring Howl's heart, Chihiro restoring Haku's name, and Nausicaä restoring the world risk the same structure: real agency routed toward male or cosmic redemption.

Hiratsuka Raichō's manifesto for the inaugural issue of *Seitō* (1911) opened with the sentence: "In the beginning, woman was truly the sun." Now, she continued, woman is a moon, living by another's light, pale as an invalid. The Miyazakian girl is solar in Raichō's sense, self-luminous and self-moving, and the image of Nausicaä walking in blue across a field of gold is a solar image. Yet the narratives often make her the moon of someone else's restoration. The tension between sun and moon is the feminist problem of the oeuvre.

6.3 Bodies in Motion

Iris Marion Young's "Throwing Like a Girl" (1980) described feminine bodily comportment under patriarchy through three modalities: ambiguous transcendence, inhibited intentionality, and discontinuous unity, a body lived as both subject and object, hesitant and fragmented. Chihiro is introduced as Young's girl, slumped in the back seat, limp, clinging, every movement tentative; Miyazaki wanted an ordinary, listless child rather than a heroine. Her descent of the exterior stairway to the boiler room, a freeze, a broken step, and a headlong, uncontrolled run, marks the beginning of a reconquest that ends with her running the length of a pipe and leaping without hesitation. Satsuki's sprints, Mei's tumbles, Kiki's stride, Fio's working body, and San's leaps share a commitment, visible in the animation's attention to weight, effort, and clumsiness, to girls' bodies as centers of intentional motion rather than surfaces for display.

Against Laura Mulvey's account of classical cinema (1975), in which woman is image and man the bearer of the look, Miyazaki's girls bear the look. Nausicaä scrutinizes spores through a lens; Fio appraises Porco's wrecked plane with an engineer's eye; Chihiro, at the end, sees through the disguise of the pigs and declares that none of them is her parents. The camera rarely fragments their bodies for display. Outside the frame, the look was reversed nonetheless. In the *rorikon* ("lolicon") boom of the early 1980s, adult male fans produced and circulated sexualized drawings of girl characters, Clarisse and then Nausicaä prominent among them, in self-published *dōjinshi* and in parts of the commercial anime press (Saitō 2000). The films' refusal to display girls did not stop others from doing so.

6.4 Voler: Flight and Theft

Hélène Cixous's "Le rire de la Méduse" (1975) exploited the double meaning of *voler*, to fly and to steal: woman's gesture, she wrote, is to fly in language and make language fly, and women are like birds and robbers who take pleasure in disordering space. The pun is exact for Miyazaki. His girls do not transcend; they steal a medium monopolized by states. Nausicaä's glider threads between warships; Kiki's broom crosses a city's air space without license; Fio builds a fighter in defiance of a fascist state; Dola's sky-pirates, a matriarchy, are air thieves by profession; Howl, in their first meeting, gives Sophie a walk across the air above the town, flight as a gift that is also a trespass. Feminine flight in Miyazaki is a theft of the sky from its owners.

6.5 Honda Masuko and the Fluttering Girl

Honda Masuko's *Ibunka to shite no kodomo* (1982) theorized the *shōjo* as a culture apart, a liminal subject suspended between childhood and the adult economy of production and reproduction, and identified her emblem as *hirahira*, the flutter of ribbons, frills, hair, and sleeves. Ōtsuka Eiji (1989) read the *shōjo* as the paradigmatic consumer of postwar Japan; John Treat (1993) as its nostalgic subject; Deborah Shamoon (2012) traced the aesthetics of passionate friendship in girls' culture. Miyazaki's distinctive move is to put the *shōjo* to work without marrying or sexualizing her. Kiki, Chihiro, Fio, and Sophie labor; none of their stories closes in a wedding; Ashitaka and San part to separate dwellings. The *shōjo*'s exteriority to the reproductive economy thus becomes a utopian position: a worker not yet captured by the gendered division of labor.

Honda's *hirahira* acquires a further charge in this oeuvre. Kiki's great red bow, Chihiro's hair tie woven by friends, Nausicaä's sash streaming above the Sea of Corruption: the girl's body is a register of the wind, a vane that shows which way the air is moving. The fluttering girl is the visible index of an invisible medium. This is the position Part V will call *anemotropic*.

6.6 The Critiques

Saitō Tamaki's *Sentō bishōjo no seishin bunseki* (2000) argued that the Japanese "beautiful fighting girl," for whom Nausicaä is a genealogical ancestor, is a "phallic girl," an imaginary object of otaku desire whose defining feature, by contrast with Western action heroines, is the absence of trauma and motive: she fights without reason, and her emptiness makes her a perfect screen. Miyazaki's heroines fail Saitō's criterion. Nausicaä carries the memory of a larval Ohmu torn from her hands in childhood, and the manga discloses a mother's withheld love; Chihiro is afraid; Kiki is depressed; Sophie is consumed by self-contempt. Their resistance to the economy Saitō describes is textual, not guaranteed by reception.

Saitō Minako's *Kōitten-ron* (1998) anatomized the "single red dot," the lone girl in a male team, and the sanctified heroine whose virtue is self-sacrifice. Miyazaki often escapes the first structure by building female collectives, Irontown's women, the Piccolo workshop, the bathhouse attendants, Dola's household, the women of the Sunflower House in *Ponyo*, but the sanctified type persists in the film of *Nausicaä* and returns in Naoko. Napier's "enchantment of estrangement" (2005) and Kumiko Saito's account of metamorphosis in the magical-girl genre (2014) frame Kiki as a de-glamorized magical girl whose magic is indistinguishable from labor. Miyazaki's criticism of animation that makes girls into objects of male fantasy does not settle what his own images do once released into the *rorikon* economy described above; Saitō Tamaki's psychoanalysis of that economy remains the necessary counter-reading.

6.7 The Late Turn: Returning the Burden

After Sophie, the redemptive girl recedes. Ponyo is five, and her love is an appetite rather than a mission; the ending's test falls on the boy, who must accept her whether fish or girl. *The Wind Rises* centers a man whose genius exempts him from care. Naoko leaves the sanatorium to marry him and then leaves him to die alone so that he will remember her beautiful, the most regressive figure in the oeuvre unless the film is read, as it can be, as an indictment of an economy of male genius that requires such self-erasure. Its last word, at least, is hers, and it is an imperative: live.

The Boy and the Heron transfers the ethical burden decisively. Mahito must confront his own malice, accept a stepmother, Natsuko, who has reason to resent him and says so, and refuse a world-stewardship that would perpetuate an old man's dream of purity. Himi, his mother as a girl, commands fire and chooses her fate, returning to her own time to bear him and to die in the fire that opens the film, an act poised between maternal sacrifice and maternal sovereignty. Kiriko, a laboring fisherwoman, feeds the souls of the unborn. In the late films girls no longer save boys; boys must save themselves by confessing. The *shōjo* survives as a position, but the position is now open to anyone willing to occupy it.

07

CHAPTER 7

Mothers, Crones, and the Labor of Care

Miyazaki's films are dramas of care in which the decisive figures are not mothers, who are characteristically absent, ill, or monstrous, but children pressed into care and old women freed by age. Read with feminist care ethics, they expose both the gendering of care and its indispensability, and they culminate in a single image, a man working with one hand while holding a dying woman's hand with the other, that crystallizes what Joan Tronto called privileged irresponsibility.

7.1 The Ethics of Care

Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) identified, against Kohlberg's ladder of justice, a moral reasoning organized by relationship and responsibility, a web rather than a hierarchy. Nel Noddings (1984) analyzed caring as engrossment in and motivational displacement toward the cared-for. Sara Ruddick's *Maternal Thinking* (1989) described a practice organized by preservative love, the fostering of growth, and training for social acceptability, and extended it toward a politics of peace. Berenice Fisher and Joan Tronto (1990) defined care as a species activity including everything we do to maintain, continue, and repair our world so that we can live in it as well as possible, and Tronto's *Moral Boundaries* (1993) named the capacity of the powerful to ignore care needs that others meet for them "privileged irresponsibility." Eva Feder Kittay's *Love's Labor* (1999) insisted that everyone is some mother's child and proposed *doulia*, care for the carer, as a principle of justice. María Puig de la Bellacasa (2017) extended care to more-than-human worlds of soil and species.

Miyazaki's oeuvre is an encyclopedia of such practice. Nausicaä tends a wounded Ohmu, her enemies, and the poisoned; Ashitaka carries wounded men out of the forest; Kiki delivers; Satsuki keeps house; Chihiro nurses Haku and doses No-Face; Sophie cleans, cooks, and nurses the very witch who cursed her; Lisa works in a home for the elderly; Kiriko feeds the unborn. Care exceeds the human in Puig de la Bellacasa's sense: Nausicaä's secret garden of spores grown in clean water, the robot that tends Laputa's garden, the forest that tends the poisoned earth.

7.2 The Absent Mother and the Parentified Girl

Mothers in Miyazaki are absent, ill, cold, or monstrous: Yasuko hospitalized, Chihiro's mother brusque and impatient, Hisako dead in a fire, Natsuko sick and ambivalent, Moro a wolf, Yubaba a tyrant whose love smothers her gigantic infant, Granmamare cosmic and remote. The burden passes to children. Satsuki is a parentified girl who cooks, packs lunches, minds her sister, and breaks only when her mother's death becomes thinkable. *Totoro* is, among other things, an account of a child's care labor and its cost, and its gods appear precisely as care for the carer: the Catbus is *doulia* in the shape of a cat. The theological claim is striking and unremarked: in Miyazaki, the sacred functions as care for those who care.

The biographical source is evident, and feminist criticism must register its limit. The idealized absent mother is a classic structure of the male imaginary, the mother as lost object, and the films seldom grant mothers interiority. Two exceptions prove the rule's awareness of itself: Lisa, a working mother whose anger at her absent husband is flashed across the bay in Morse code, and Dola, a pirate matriarch who commands grown sons and adopts a girl.

7.3 The Mother of the Weapon

Ruddick hoped maternal thinking could ground a politics of peace. The *Nausicaä* manga tests that hope to destruction. Nausicaä becomes mother to the God Warrior, the engineered weapon that ended the old world, names it Ohma, "innocence," and is called mother by it; she guides it into battle, it dies, and its emanations sicken her. Kotani Mari's analyses of the techno-maternal in Japanese science fiction (1997) illuminate the figure: the love that humanizes the weapon also enables it. Ueno Chizuko's *Nashonarizumu to jendā* (1998; trans. 2004) showed that Japanese women were not only victims of the war state but participants in it, mobilized through a maternalist ideology. Nausicaä's motherhood of Ohma is the oeuvre's most uncompromising meditation on maternal complicity, and the women of Irontown, liberated by forging guns, are its quieter echo.

7.4 The Crones

Beauvoir's *La Vieillesse* (1970) described old age as a second othering: the old are expelled from the community of projects, and old women doubly so. Miyazaki's gallery of old women is unrivaled in popular cinema: blind Obaba, Captain Dola, the neighbor Granny who holds Satsuki as she weeps, the elegant Madame and her housekeeper in *Kiki*, the twin witches Yubaba and Zeniba, the Witch of the Waste, Sophie at ninety, the women of the Sunflower House, and the seven elderly servants of *The Boy and the Heron*, who end as tiny guardian figures in Mahito's pocket.

Sophie's curse is the oeuvre's central feminist parable. Young, she is self-effacing, convinced of her plainness, laboring in her late father's hat shop. Cursed into old age, she becomes frank, mobile, and commanding, released from the economy of youthful appearance and from the duty to efface herself; her body's age fluctuates with her

confidence, softening in sleep and courage. Age becomes liberation from the gaze rather than exile from the human, an inversion of Beauvoir's diagnosis. The twins of *Spirited Away* divide old age into its two economies: Yubaba accumulates, while Zeniba, who sits knitting a hair tie with No-Face and a transformed baby, gives.

Ueno Chizuko's later work on aging and care in a super-aged society (2007; 2011) supplies the context for the Sunflower House of *Ponyo*, a day center for the elderly beside a kindergarten, an intergenerational architecture across which Sōsuke runs between preschoolers and old women. In the drowned world of the film's climax the women rise from their wheelchairs and run, a utopia of restored mobility offered without comment. Studio Ghibli opened an in-house nursery for employees' children in 2008, translating the image into institutional practice.

7.5 The One-Handed Engineer

The central image of care in *The Wind Rises* is double-edged. Naoko lies in bed in the borrowed room where they live; Jirō calculates with his right hand while holding her hand with his left; he asks whether he may smoke, and she tells him to go ahead. The scene is tender and appalling at once: care and production intertwined, production prevailing, the cigarette the contamination of care by the air of work. An antismoking organization complained of the film's tobacco; the complaint missed that the smoke is the point. Tronto's privileged irresponsibility describes Jirō exactly: his genius exempts him from care, and Naoko's departure to die alone at the sanatorium, so that he will remember her beautiful, absorbs the cost. Sontag's *Illness as Metaphor* (1978) dismantled the romance of the consumptive beloved; the film both rehearses that romance and exposes the moral economy it serves.

7.6 Care as the Provision of Breathable Conditions

The sanatorium's open-air cure, patients wrapped in blankets on frozen balconies, Naoko in the snow, recalls that care has historically been the management of air. Care in Miyazaki is atmospheric throughout. Nausicaä discovers clean air beneath the toxic forest; Satsuki and Mei fling open the shutters of a dark house and laugh until the soot sprites leave; Kamaji keeps the boiler breathing; the women of Irontown breathe for the furnace. Read together, these scenes yield a definition that Part V will raise to a thesis: care, in Miyazaki, is the provision of breathable conditions for others.

08

CHAPTER 8

Ecofeminism and Its Discontents: Irontown, the Bathhouse, and the Contract

Miyazaki engages ecofeminism's founding equation, the parallel domination of women and nature, only to split it. Nausicaä and San inherit the equation; Eboshi breaks it by liberating women through the conquest of a forest; and the bathhouse relocates domination from nature to the contract. The result is an ecofeminism without essence.

8.1 The Ecofeminist Frame

Françoise d'Eaubonne coined *écoféminisme* in *Le Féminisme ou la mort* (1974). Carolyn Merchant's *The Death of Nature* (1980) argued that the Scientific Revolution replaced an organic cosmos, frequently imagined as female, with a mechanistic one that licensed exploitation. Karen Warren (1990) identified a "logic of domination" linking hierarchies of value. Val Plumwood's *Feminism and the Mastery of Nature* (1993) anatomized the Western dualisms of reason and nature, male and female, human and animal, through five features: backgrounding, the denial of dependence; radical exclusion, or hyperseparation; incorporation, the definition of the subordinate solely in relation to the master; instrumentalism; and homogenization. She warned that merely reversing the dualism, valorizing the subordinated side, reproduces its logic. Vandana Shiva's *Staying Alive* (1988) and Maria Mies and Shiva's *Ecofeminism* (1993) grounded the theory in the Chipko women who embraced trees against loggers in the Garhwal Himalaya and in a "subsistence perspective."

The Japanese affinity is Ishimure Michiko's *Kugai jōdo* (1969), a polyphonic witness to Minamata disease in which fishing families, the poisoned sea, and women's voices articulate an ecology of grief. Miyazaki has cited Minamata Bay as a seed of *Nausicaä*'s world for a paradox that unsettled him: once mercury had closed the bay to fishing, the fish returned in abundance to waters no longer fit for human use (Miyazaki 2009). Nature could recover by excluding humanity, a thought that is both consolation and indictment.

8.2 Nausicaä Between Essence and Science

The film of *Nausicaä* lends itself to ecofeminist iconography: a princess who loves insects, communes with the Ohmu, and speaks for the forest against militarist empires. Plumwood's warning applies, since the image risks the essentialist reversal in which the girl simply is nature. But Nausicaä is also an experimental scientist. In a hidden room beneath the castle she cultivates the forest's toxic plants in clean water and sand drawn from deep wells and discovers that they are harmless; the poison lies in the soil, not in the plants. Evelyn Fox Keller's *A Feeling for the Organism* (1983), on the geneticist Barbara McClintock, whose discoveries in maize issued from intimate and patient attention, describes Nausicaä's epistemology exactly. Haraway's "Situated Knowledges" (1988) supplies its philosophy: objectivity as partial, embodied, and accountable rather than the view from nowhere. Nausicaä descends into the forest, touches, samples, and risks her lungs. This is feminist epistemology, not feminine intuition. The manga radicalizes it: Nausicaä becomes commander, killer, and finally the arbiter of the species' future, no longer an emblem of nature but an agent of judgment.

8.3 Irontown: The Cyborg and the Goddess

Irontown is the oeuvre's most explicit feminist community. Lady Eboshi paid off the debts by which its women had been sold into brothels and gave them paid work, dignity, and arms; she shelters people with Hansen's disease, called lepers in the film, treats them as human, and employs them to design her guns. The women are militarily competent, defending the town while the men are away, and they speak of sex and desire with a mocking frankness that the film presents as theirs to command: women once sold for sex now joke about it as free agents. And Irontown is built on the destruction of a forest: its iron demands charcoal and iron sand, its prosperity strips the hills, its guns wound the gods. In Plumwood's terms, Eboshi achieves emancipation by enlisting women on the master side of the human–nature dualism. Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) closes by preferring the cyborg to the goddess; Eboshi is the cyborg, emancipation through technology and the alliance of the stigmatized, without nostalgia for origins, while San, raised by a wolf-god and repudiating her humanity, stands nearest the goddess. Miyazaki refuses to choose. The film ends with Eboshi's arm torn away by the severed head of Moro, her resolve to build a better village, and San's refusal to forgive humans even as she loves Ashitaka.

Audre Lorde's "The Uses of Anger" (1981) argued that women's anger is loaded with information and energy and must not be dismissed as excess; San's rage is legitimate knowledge of injury, and the film does not ask her to surrender it. Ueno Chizuko's work on women's participation in the war state is the necessary counterweight: Irontown is a feminist community that manufactures guns. A further objection concerns mediation. Ashitaka stands between the women, and a man arbitrating between two women is a familiar patriarchal figure. The film's partial reply is that he mediates not by authority but by suffering and by carrying, that he fails to prevent

the catastrophe, and that the restitution of the god's head is performed jointly with San.

8.4 The Bathhouse and the Contract

Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) argued that the story of the social contract conceals a prior sexual contract establishing men's access to women's bodies, and that contract, presented as the form of freedom, is a mechanism for creating subordination in marriage, employment, and prostitution. *Spirited Away*'s bathhouse runs on contract. To survive, Chihiro must ask for work, since in this world speech binds and Yubaba is sworn to employ anyone who asks; she signs, and her name is taken. The setting carries precise historical weight. The *yuna* of Edo-period bathhouses were frequently prostitutes, and the film's contract reproduces the structure of Japan's licensed prostitution system, abolished only in 1946 under the Occupation: women and girls, often sold by impoverished families to cover debts, were bound to brothel keepers by advance-debt indentures (*zenshakkin*), confined to their quarter, and given professional names in place of their own. In the film, parents consume what they have not paid for, and a daughter's indenture redeems them. Chihiro is ten. The film never sexualizes her; it assigns the structure of indentured sex work, debt, confinement, and renaming, to a child. Miyazaki is reported to have remarked, at the time of the film's release, that contemporary Japanese society had come to resemble the sex industry. The contract is the instrument that converts a self into labor-power, and the renaming is its signature.

Chihiro's counter-pact is woven from memory, gift, and refusal. She remembers Haku's true name, the river into which she once fell; she gives the bitter dumpling that the polluted river-god gave her; she refuses No-Face's gold. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) showed that the gift binds persons into a fabric of obligation and return. No-Face's gold is the anti-gift, a gift that purchases, creating no bond but consumption, and it turns to dirt by morning. Chihiro's dumpling makes him vomit everything he has devoured. The economy is reversed by a gift that is also a purgative.

8.5 Le Guin's Forest and the Chipko Embrace

Le Guin's *The Word for World Is Forest* (1972) imagines colonists logging a forested planet and enslaving its inhabitants, in whose language the word for forest and the word for world are one; the gentle Athsheans learn to kill, and the learning cannot be undone. *Mononoke* shares the structure, a forest colonized, gods taught hatred, violence that once learned is irreversible, while refusing Le Guin's binary, since Irontown's colonists are themselves the outcast and the trafficked. Against the Chipko embrace, San does not hug trees; she attacks. Miyazaki's ecofeminism is militant rather than maternal.

8.6 Trans-Corporeality and the Lepers

Stacy Alaimo's *Bodily Natures* (2010) theorized *trans-corporeality*, the intermeshing of human bodies with environments, especially toxic ones, such that the body becomes a site of environmental knowledge. The *Nausicaä* manga makes trans-corporeality a plot: the present inhabitants' bodies were engineered to tolerate the poisoned world, and pure air makes them bleed. Ashitaka carries the forest's hatred in his flesh. The lepers of Irontown, bodies marked by disease and stigma, provide the film's most moving voice: their bandaged leader tells Ashitaka that life is suffering and yet he wishes to live, and that Eboshi alone treated them as human. The film neither cures nor pities them; they are engineers. Those whose bodies already register the world's poisons are its first witnesses, and the politics of ecology is inseparable from a politics of vulnerability.

8.7 Ecofeminism Without Essence

Miyazaki accepts ecofeminism's diagnosis that the dominations of women, outcasts, and nature are entangled, while refusing its essentialist cure. His women are not nature: they are scientists, industrialists, engineers, laborers, warriors, and witches. What unites the domination of nature and of women in his films is not a shared essence but a shared mechanism, the contract that converts persons and forests into resources and the atmosphere of consumption that No-Face embodies. The alternative proposed is not a return to nature but a different pact.

PART IV

The Humanist Problematic

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Better a Pig

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CHAPTER 9

Better a Pig: Misanthropic Humanism and the Jamming of the Anthropological Machine

Miyazaki is a humanist who does not much like humanity. His work disqualifies the human as master of nature, history, and meaning and requalifies it as participant; its signature device, the transformation of humans into animals and of animals into persons, jams what Giorgio Agamben called the anthropological machine.

9.1 The Misanthrope Who Loves Children

Miyazaki's interviews are notoriously misanthropic. He has lamented humanity's numbers, imagined the city drowned and returned to grass, and declared that peoples do not learn. He also insists that one must not tell children the world is hopeless, and that films for children must affirm that being alive is good (Miyazaki 2009; 2014). The contradiction is constitutive. His humanism is a commitment to the possibility of human goodness carried by those not yet captured by the adult world, joined to contempt for the species' collective conduct. The human is not loved as it is; it is held open as a possibility. This is misanthropic humanism.

9.2 The Dignity Tradition: Pico and Kant

In Pico della Mirandola's *Oratio de hominis dignitate* (1486), God tells Adam that he has been given no fixed seat, no form of his own, and no proper function, so that as his own free and sovereign maker and molder he may fashion himself in whatever form he prefers. Pico's human is a chameleon, the being without a nature, origin of the humanist dignity of self-fashioning. Kant's *Grundlegung* (1785) located dignity in rational beings as ends in themselves, members of a kingdom of ends from which animals are excluded except through indirect duties. Miyazaki inherits Pico's openness, since his humans are unfinished and can become beasts or saints, but refuses its sovereignty. His humans do not fashion themselves; they are fashioned by curses, gifts, and media. Sophie's age, Porco's snout, Howl's feathers, Ashitaka's arm, and Chihiro's name are all made in relation rather than by sovereign will. The unfinished human is co-fashioned.

9.3 Montaigne's Humility

In the "Apologie de Raimond Sebond" (*Essais* II.12, 1580), Montaigne asks whether, when he plays with his cat, she is not amusing herself with him more than he with her. The *Apologie* dismantles human presumption by comparison with animals, and "Des cannibales" (I.31) turns the charge of barbarism back upon Europe. Miyazaki practices Montaignean humility. Cats are subjects, from Jiji to the Catbus. The Emishi, the Forest People of the manga, who have renounced fire and live inside the toxic jungle, and the peasants of the Dorok empire possess dignities the empires lack; the "barbarians" are frequently wiser than the civilized.

9.4 Marx's Metabolism

In the 1844 manuscripts Marx called nature the inorganic body of the human, with which the human must remain in continuous interchange if it is not to die. *Capital* later theorized a "metabolic rift" between town and country, a concept recovered by John Bellamy Foster (2000) and radicalized by Saitō Kōhei (2017; 2023). Miyazaki's post-Marxian humanism keeps the metabolic insight while dropping the teleology. His films are studies in metabolic rift: an urban family returning to the countryside in *Totoro*; a suburban new town built over a buried river in *Spirited Away*; a sea choked with refuse in *Ponyo*; a forest metabolized into iron in *Mononoke*. Breathing is the most elementary metabolism, the ceaseless exchange of matter between a body and its world.

9.5 The Aviator's Humanism

Saint-Exupéry's *Terre des hommes* (1939) found from the cockpit a humanism of the bond: comradeship among airmail pilots, the earth seen from above as the dwelling of humankind, and a responsibility felt in contributing one's stone to the building of the world. It is the nearest Western affinity for Miyazaki's flying humanism, visible in Porco's comrades, Kiki's deliveries, and the Mehve. Yet Saint-Exupéry died in 1944 on a military reconnaissance flight, and the aviator's humanism is shadowed by the war it served. Caproni in *The Wind Rises* is Saint-Exupéry's dark twin, the same lyricism of flight joined to the knowledge that the sky swallows its dreamers. Porco's vision of dead airmen rising to form a white river across the sky is the aviator's humanism transfigured into elegy.

9.6 Existentialism, Anti-Humanism, and the Measure

Sartre's "L'existentialisme est un humanisme" (1946) declared that existence precedes essence and that the human is what it makes of itself. Heidegger's *Brief über den Humanismus* (1947) replied that humanism thinks the human too lowly, as a rational animal, and that the human is rather the shepherd of Being, dwelling in language as Being's house. *Spirited Away* is Heideggerian in one respect: words bind, and the name is the dwelling of a person. Heidegger's politics, and what Irigaray would call his forgetting of air (Chapter 11), mark the limit of the affinity.

Camus's *L'Homme révolté* (1951) set against the ideologies of history a revolt that respects limits, a "thought of noon" whose Mediterranean virtue is measure; *Noces* (1938) celebrated nuptials with the world at Tipasa. *Porco Rosso* is a Camusian film: an Adriatic noon, a refusal of fascism that does not convert into a counter-ideology, a man who revolts by becoming a pig and maintains an ironic, measured dignity. His declaration that it is better to be a pig than a fascist is a Camusian sentence. Simone Weil's *L'Enracinement* (1949) called rootedness perhaps the most important and least recognized need of the human soul. Sheeta's answer to Muska in *Laputa*, a peasant song of her valley binding human life to soil, seed, birds, and the injunction to live with the wind, is a Weilian answer.

9.7 The Face and the Faceless

For Emmanuel Levinas (*Totalité et infini*, 1961), the face of the other is an ethical command prior to knowledge, an interdiction of murder that resists possession. Kaonashi, "No-Face," is a mask over a translucent shadow; he can speak only in the voices of those he has swallowed; he becomes whatever the room desires and consumes without limit. He is the subject without a face, and therefore without the command that would limit him. Chihiro's refusal of his gold is the first act that addresses him as someone rather than as a source of wealth; he follows her, and at Zeniba's cottage he finds a place and a task. Levinas's essay on Bobby (1975), the stray dog who greeted the prisoners of a Nazi labor camp as human beings when no one else did, names a further Miyazakian theme: animals as witnesses to human dignity. Yakul's loyalty, Moro's grudging respect, the Ohmu's recognition of Nausicaä, and the wheezing old dog Heen in *Howl* are Bobbys.

9.8 The Anthropological Machine Jammed

Agamben's *L'aperto* (2002) describes Western thought as an anthropological machine that produces the human by separating it from the animal, including the animal within the human, and in so doing produces bare life. Miyazaki's metamorphoses jam the machine. Chihiro's parents become pigs by eating, consumption turning humans into livestock. Porco becomes a pig after the war through a self-imposed curse, guilt and refusal combined; the snout is his secession from the human order of states and air forces. Howl becomes a monster through war; Haku is dragon and boy, San wolf and girl, Ponyo fish and girl. The border is crossed in both directions, and each crossing is morally indexed: humans become beasts through greed, war, or guilt, while animals become persons through love and courage. The human is not a species but a moral achievement available across species and forfeitable by humans. Haraway's companion species (2008), Braidotti's zoe-centered egalitarianism (2013), and Emanuele Coccia's *Métamorphoses* (2020), for which every living being is a metamorphosis of others, articulate the same intuition. *Kemushi no Boro* (2018), Miyazaki's short about a newborn caterpillar's first encounter with air and light, is its quiet manifesto.

9.9 After Man: Wynter, Fanon, and Japan's Reckoning

Sylvia Wynter (2003) argued that the Western bourgeois conception of Man, first as political subject and then as *homo oeconomicus*, has overrepresented itself as the human as such. Miyazaki's critique of *homo oeconomicus* is pointed: the bathhouse, No-Face, the parents' feast, the bubble-era theme park left to rot. Frantz Fanon closed *Les Damnés de la terre* (1961) by urging the colonized to leave Europe's humanism behind and work out new concepts for a new humanity; Edward Said (2004) reclaimed humanism as critique rather than complacency. Miyazaki's position is complicated by Japan's double place as a non-Western modernity that imitated Western empire, annexing Taiwan (1895) and Korea (1910), seizing Manchuria (1931), and waging war across China from 1937 and Southeast Asia from 1941. *The Wind Rises* was criticized in South Korea and China for aestheticizing the Zero.

In Japan, Miyazaki's 2013 essay opposed constitutional revision and called for a proper apology and compensation to the so-called comfort women: women and girls, many of them Korean, whom the Imperial Japanese Army and Navy forced into sexual slavery in military brothels. The government's 1993 Kōno Statement acknowledged the military's involvement and the coercion of the women, though their numbers, and the extent to which the military itself conducted recruitment, remain disputed, with estimates running from tens of thousands upward. The essay drew nationalist attack (Miyazaki 2013).

The Zero's war lies outside the film's frame. Japanese army and navy aircraft, Honjō Kiro's G3M bomber prominent among them, bombed Chongqing and other Chinese cities from 1938 to 1943, killing thousands of civilians. The Zero made its combat debut escorting those raids in September 1940, and from October 1944 Zeros were the principal aircraft of the navy's special attack units, organized under Vice Admiral Ōnishi Takijirō, which sent several thousand young pilots to deliberate deaths. The film's narrative closes before Pearl Harbor, and its last dream is a field of wrecked aircraft, none of which, Jirō says, came back. A Japanese humanism must face Japanese empire, and Miyazaki's is a humanism that knows its complicity even when it averts its eyes.

9.10 Watsuji Without the Nation

The most adequate name for Miyazaki's humanism is Watsujian rather than Kantian: the human as betweenness, *aidagara*, a relational rather than substantial definition. It is Watsuji stripped of the nationalism that marred his wartime ethics, in which the state figured as the highest totality, and extended, as Augustin Berque's mesology extended Watsuji's *fūdo* into a theory of the human milieu (Berque 2000), to nonhumans and to the medium itself. The human is a between, and the between is breathed.

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CHAPTER 10

Against Purity: Contamination as the Condition of Life

The decisive philosophical act of Miyazaki's oeuvre is the refusal of purity. It is performed most radically at the end of the *Nausicaä* manga, where the heroine destroys a stored, purified future humanity for the sake of the contaminated present, and it organizes every film from *Mononoke* to *The Boy and the Heron* in four registers: ecological, eugenic, moral, and national.

10.1 The Crypt of Shuwa

The manga's final volumes, completed in 1994, overturn everything the film had allowed its audience to believe. The Sea of Corruption is not nature's spontaneous revolt but an artifact: the scientists of the old industrial civilization engineered the forest and its creatures as a planetary purification system, whose fungi draw poison from the soil and, dying, leave behind crystalline sand and clean water. The present peoples, Nausicaä among them, were engineered as well, adapted to survive in the poisoned world; their bodies now require the poison, and in purified air they cough blood. When the purification is complete they will die out. In the Crypt of Shuwa the old world's builders stored the means of a proper restoration, a humanity purified of aggression and held in embryonic form, while a separate Garden, tended by its master, preserves the plants, music, and art of the vanished civilization and offers Nausicaä rest within it.

Nausicaä refuses both the Garden and the Crypt. She answers the Crypt's master that life is a light flickering in darkness, that the forest, the Ohmu, and the living peoples possess their own will and their own life apart from any design, and that she will not entrust the future to a plan that regards the living as provisional. She has the God Warrior destroy the Crypt, killing its master and the embryos of the purified humanity stored within it. She resolves to carry the knowledge of her people's fate herself rather than lay it on them. Inaba Shin'ichirō (1996) read the ending as utopian thought pressed to its critical point: every design for a pure humanity presupposes the erasure of the existing one.

The ending is scandalous, and Miyazaki does not soften the scandal. Nausicaä destroys the unborn, withholds the truth, and acts alone. There is no innocent

position available to her, only a choice between two impurities, consent to the extinction of the living or the destruction of the designed, and she chooses the living: contaminated, mortal, unjustified. The Crypt is teleology's monument, history as a plan with an engineered terminus, and in destroying it Nausicaä destroys the end of history. The manga's conclusion is the narrative form of Miyazaki's abandonment of Marxism traced in Chapter 1, and its consequences govern everything he made afterward.

10.2 Purity and Danger

Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place: where there is dirt there is a system of classification, and pollution beliefs police its borders. Shinto organizes the sacred through *kegare*, the defilement of death, blood, and disease, and *harae*, ritual purification. *Spirited Away*'s bathhouse is a *harae* machine to which the gods come to be cleansed. Its central purification inverts the ritual's premise. The Stink Spirit, so foul that food rots at its approach, proves to be a river-god clogged with human refuse; Chihiro finds a "thorn" in its side, a bicycle, and the staff haul out a torrent of garbage before the old god, laughing, departs. Nothing original is restored. What was dumped is removed, and the cleansing is an act of labor rather than a return to origin. When Chihiro stamps on the black slug Haku has vomited, Kamaji teaches her the children's warding gesture against pollution and "cuts" it with his hand, purification as playground ritual, treated with affectionate irony.

Douglas cuts against Miyazaki's own nostalgia, since the purity of *satoyama* is itself a classification. But dirt in his films is ontologically productive rather than merely misplaced: soot sprites carry coal, smoke drives the boiler, the river-god's sludge conceals a gift, and the poison of the Sea of Corruption is the vehicle of the world's healing.

10.3 Abjection

Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) described the abject as what the subject must expel to constitute itself, bodily fluids, decay, the corpse, the undifferentiated maternal body, and which therefore troubles identity, system, and order, fascinating as it repels. *Spirited Away* is Miyazaki's most abject film: No-Face's vomit, Haku's retching, the river-god's sludge, the parents' gorging and their swine bodies, and Boh, Yubaba's gigantic infant, smothered in a nursery of cushions, the abject maternal in its most literal form. Chihiro's growth is a passage through abjection rather than an escape from it. She thrusts her arm into the river-god's filth; she lets No-Face disgorge everything he has swallowed; she feeds Haku the bitter dumpling and crushes what he expels. The abject is a boundary to be traversed, not eliminated. Maturity, in this film, is the capacity to handle dirt without being defined by it.

10.4 Contamination as Collaboration

Anna Tsing's *The Mushroom at the End of the World* (2015) treats contamination as the condition of collaboration: every encounter transforms its parties, and survival in disturbed landscapes is necessarily collaborative, as the matsutake that flourishes in damaged forests attests. The Sea of Corruption is a fungal forest that remediates poisoned soil, and its insects are compost-makers. Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) insists that we are compost rather than posthuman and that the task is to remain with damaged worlds rather than flee them toward salvation. Timothy Morton's *Ecology without Nature* (2007) argued that the idea of Nature as a pristine outside obstructs ecological thought. The manga anticipates the argument with startling force: the most "natural" thing in its world, the vast forest and its insects, is a biotechnology, and Nausicaä's love for it is love for an engineered, toxic, healing, living system. Nature and artifice are not opposites; they are what Haraway calls naturecultures. Alaimo's trans-corporeality (Chapter 8) completes the picture: bodies are already contaminated, and their contamination is their history.

10.5 Purity's Politics

The eugenic register is the most urgent. The Crypt's stored embryos are a eugenic archive, a humanity improved by design rather than accompanied in its imperfection. The manga reached its conclusion while Japan's own Eugenic Protection Law (1948–1996) remained in force. Under it, prefectural eugenic review boards authorized, and physicians performed, the sterilization of about 25,000 people with intellectual disabilities, mental illness, or conditions deemed hereditary, some 16,500 of them without consent and some of them children; the Supreme Court of Japan declared the law unconstitutional in July 2024. The law named Hansen's disease among its grounds. In the national sanatoria to which the Leprosy Prevention Law confined patients, marriage was commonly conditioned on vasectomy and pregnancies were terminated, a practice begun in 1915 at Zensei Hospital, the forerunner of Tama Zenshōen, under its director Mitsuda Kensuke. Japan repealed the Leprosy Prevention Law in 1996, the same year it revised the Eugenic Protection Law; in 2001 the Kumamoto District Court found the segregation policy unconstitutional, and the government accepted the ruling and apologized.

Princess Mononoke, released in 1997, places at the moral center of Irontown a community of people with Hansen's disease whom Eboshi treats as human and who design its weapons. Miyazaki has spoken of walks through the National Sanatorium Tama Zenshōen, near the studio, during the film's planning. Whatever its intention, the conjunction is historically exact: the oeuvre's refusal of purity coincides with the dismantling of Japan's legal apparatus of hygienic exclusion.

The moral register returns in *The Boy and the Heron*. The great-uncle sustains his world by balancing a tower of blocks that he describes as stones untainted by malice, and he asks Mahito to inherit the task. Mahito declines, showing the wound he inflicted on himself as the mark of his own malice, and chooses to return to a world of war, deceit, and friendship. The Parakeet King, impatient with deliberation, hacks

the tower apart and the world collapses. The old man's pure world, built from malice-free stones, is the Crypt of Shuwa in miniature, and Mahito's refusal repeats Nausicaä's. The ecological register appears in *Ponyo*'s Fujimoto, a former human who loathes his species for fouling the sea and hoards an elixir to restore the ocean's primordial age; his project is undone by his daughter's love and her appetite for ham, and the Devonian fish that swim briefly over drowned roads are absorbed into a renewed ordinary world.

The national register is subtler. The laurel forest and Amino's margins already deny the myth of a homogeneous Japan. Yoshioka (2008) is right that *Spirited Away* constructs a nostalgic "Japaneseness," but the bathhouse that houses it is a pastiche of Japanese, Chinese, and Western idioms, a Japaneseness constituted by its impurities. Miyazaki's Japan, like his forest, is a mixture.

10.6 The Waters of Forgetfulness

Ivan Illich's *H2O and the Waters of Forgetfulness* (1985) argued that modern water, "H2O," is an industrial stuff, a fluid for carrying away waste, that has lost the imaginal depth of historical water, the waters of Lethe and Mnemosyne that once carried a city's memory and dreams. Haku is the Kohaku River, filled in and paved over for apartment blocks, a river reduced to infrastructure and stripped of its name. Chihiro remembers falling into it as a small child and being carried to the shallows, and her memory restores the god's name and frees him. The Sea Railway runs over water that has drowned its tracks, carrying translucent passengers to stations no one alights at: Lethe as commuter line. Purity, in Illich's account, is the modern regime of water as cleanser, a regime of forgetting. Miyazaki's films restore memory to water, and, as the next chapter argues, to air.

10.7 Living With

The refusal of purity is the center of gravity of the oeuvre. From 1994 onward, no film restores an origin. *Mononoke* ends not with the old forest but with new growth and a single *kodama*; *Spirited Away* returns its heroine to an ambiguous ordinary; *Howl* ends in an unfinished peace; *Ponyo* in a mixed world; *The Wind Rises* in a ruined empire and an imperative to live; *The Boy and the Heron* with a return to war. The ethic is Haraway's staying with the trouble, given a precise operational form: contamination is to be metabolized rather than eradicated. To live in a contaminated world is to breathe it. The final chapter asks what kind of humanism follows when breath, rather than purity, becomes the unit of life.

PART V

Synthesis

CHAPTER 11

Conspiratio



11

CHAPTER 11

Conspiratio: Toward a Pneumatic Humanism

The tenets reconstructed in Parts II through IV are aspects of one position: animism as attention, violence as contagion, the convivial threshold, the *shōjo* as position, care as the provision of breathable conditions, the humanism of the between, and the refusal of purity. This chapter names that position *conspiratorial humanism*. In it the human is defined by breathing together with others in a shared and contaminated atmosphere, and ethics, politics, and form are organized around the reading and the distribution of air.

11.1 Anima, Anemos, Pneuma, Ki

The vocabulary of spirit in every language this study has touched is a vocabulary of breath. Latin has *anima* and *spiritus*, from *spirare*, to breathe. Greek has *pneuma*, from *pnein*, and *psychē*, originally the breath that leaves the dying. Hebrew *ruach* is at once wind and spirit, Sanskrit has *prāṇa*, and Chinese *qi* and Japanese *ki* or *ke* mean vapor, breath, mood, and atmosphere. In Japanese, the word for breath, *iki*, sounds together with the verb to live, *ikiru*. Whatever the etymological standing of that echo, it has long been available to poets, and Miyazaki's taglines exploit it: *Ikiro*, *Ikineba*. *Spirare* yields inspiration, expiration, and conspiration. In classical Latin *conspirare* meant to agree, to act in concert, and to plot. The ambivalence between concord and conspiracy is retained here deliberately, because Miyazaki's heroines are in concord with the world and in conspiracy against its owners.

In a late lecture, "The Cultivation of Conspiracy" (1998; published 2002), Ivan Illich recalled the early Christian *conspiratio*: the liturgical kiss of peace, in which members of a congregation shared breath and thereby constituted themselves as a community of one spirit. Against an age of systems that absorb every relation into management, Illich proposed friendship as a conspiracy to be cultivated, a breathing-together outside institutions. The term carries three senses in what follows. Ontologically, co-respiration is the condition of living. Ethically, the shared breath grounds obligation. Politically, conspiracy is the alliance of those who must breathe against those who would enclose the air.

11.2 The Forgotten Element

Luce Irigaray's *L'oubli de l'air chez Martin Heidegger* (1983) charges Western metaphysics, culminating in Heidegger, with thinking Being from the earth: ground, foundation, the forest clearing in which Being shows itself. In doing so it forgets air, the element that makes any clearing possible, that gives without being thought, that is everywhere and nowhere, and that the tradition has coded maternal and feminine. To forget air is to forget the debt of life to what sustains it. In *Between East and West* (1999; trans. 2002), Irigaray turned to the yogic cultivation of breath to imagine a culture of breathing, in which spiritual autonomy and the relation between two persons might rest on the conscious sharing of air. Gaston Bachelard's *L'Air et les songes* (1943) had already proposed an "ascensional psychology," a dynamic imagination of air whose dreams of flight figure lightness, freedom, and sublimation. Tim Ingold (2007) urged anthropology to restore the weather-world of wind, sky, and light to a discipline that had imagined people living on a surface rather than within a medium.

Miyazaki's oeuvre is the great anamnesis of air in modern visual culture. It remembers what metaphysics forgot, and it does so through the very figures Irigaray associated with the forgotten element: girls, mothers, and the unseen medium. It avoids essentialism by making remembrance a practice, the reading of wind, rather than a nature. It also corrects Bachelard. His air is vertical, a medium of ascension and sublimation; Miyazaki's is lateral and relational. The glider skims, the Catbus runs across the treetops, Kiki follows the coastline. What the films imagine is not sublimation but circulation.

11.3 Three Atmospheres

Atmoterror. Peter Sloterdijk's *Luftbeben* (2002; trans. *Terror from the Air*, 2009) dates the twentieth century from 22 April 1915. On that day German troops released chlorine at Ypres and attacked not their enemies' bodies but the environment those bodies had to breathe. Atmoterrorism, the weaponization of the conditions of life, culminates in three forms: the gas chambers in which Nazi Germany murdered millions of people, the great majority of them Jews; the firestorms that British and American bombers raised over Hamburg in 1943 and Dresden in 1945, and that American B-29s raised over Tokyo in March 1945; and the United States' atomic bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki. Its intellectual correlate is the "explication" of the atmosphere: air ceases to be an unnoticed background and becomes an object of design, warfare, and management.

Miyazaki was born into atmoterror on both of its sides. He survived an American incendiary raid, and his family's firm made parts for the Zero, the fighter that escorted Japan's bombers over Chongqing. His films are saturated with it:

- the Seven Days of Fire, and the God Warrior whose weapon issues from its mouth as a burning exhalation;

- the Pejite plan to turn a stampede of Ohmu into a weapon, and the Dorok's engineered miasma in the manga;
- the destructive light that Muska likens to the fire that fell on Sodom and Gomorrah;
- Howl's burning cities, Jirō's bombers, and the firestorm that opens *The Boy and the Heron*.

Rob Nixon's *Slow Violence* (2011) names atmoterror's attritional form, and its agents can be named as well:

- the sulfur-oxide emissions of the Yokkaichi petrochemical complex, whose asthma epidemic led a court to hold six companies liable in 1972;
- the methylmercury that the Chisso Corporation discharged into Minamata Bay;
- the radioactive release from Tokyo Electric Power Company's Fukushima Daiichi plant after the earthquake and tsunami of March 2011.

After Fukushima, Studio Ghibli hung a banner on its building declaring that it wished to make films with electricity not generated by nuclear power. The film of *Nausicaä* appeared in March 1984; that December, methyl isocyanate leaking from the Union Carbide India pesticide plant killed thousands in Bhopal. The masks were never merely mythic.

Kūki. Yamamoto Shichihei's "*Kūki*" *no kenkyū* (1977) anatomized the "air" that governs Japanese collective decision. It is an atmosphere of consensus that decides without anyone deciding, cannot be argued with, and renders the irrational compulsory. Yamamoto's central case is the 1945 decision to send the battleship *Yamato* on a suicide sortie to Okinawa, which participants afterward said had been impossible to oppose given the air of the meeting. To "read the air," *kūki o yomu*, is the everyday imperative of conformity; in 2007 "KY," for one who cannot read it, became a national buzzword for social failure.

In Miyazaki, *kūki* is the atmosphere of the bathhouse when No-Face arrives, as greed spreads through the staff like a gas. No-Face is *kūki* incarnate: faceless, speaking only in the voices of those he has swallowed, swelling with whatever the room desires. Chihiro alone does not want his gold. She cannot read the air because she is reading something else, the wind that leads toward Haku. *The Wind Rises* is the film of *kūki*. Jirō breathes the air of a militarizing state without noticing it, and his aesthetic innocence is a way of inhaling consensus while believing oneself above it. Castorp's warnings, and the secret police who come looking for Jirō, register what he does not.

Kaze. Against weaponized air and conformist air, Miyazaki's films propose *kaze*, wind: the moving air of a shared world. It belongs to no one. It carries spores and seeds, smells and songs, news and poison, and it must be read rather than obeyed. The Valley of the Wind survives because a sea wind holds the toxic spores at bay; its people watch the sky, and Nausicaä is a *kaze-tsukai*, one who works with the wind. Because the wind carries poison as well as life, reading it is a skill of discrimination, not an act of worship. In *The Wind Rises* the wind is the lovers' go-between. It

snatches Jirō's hat on a train, Naoko catches it, and they exchange Valéry's line as call and response; years later it carries off her parasol, and he catches it. The wind conspires.

11.4 The Fū-Lexicon

The Sino-Japanese graph for wind, 風 (*fū*; Chinese *fēng*), is the root of a whole vocabulary of milieu and manners:

- *fūdo*, climate or milieu, literally "wind and earth";
- *fūkei*, landscape, "wind and view";
- *fūzoku*, customs, which in contemporary usage is also a euphemism for the sex industry;
- *fūryū*, refined elegance, "flowing wind";
- *fūshi*, satire, wind given a voice;
- *fūhyō*, rumor, which after March 2011 named the reputational damage carried by fear of radiation.

Watsuji's *Fūdo* (1935) classified human cultures by three climates, monsoon, desert, and meadow, in a theory notorious for its determinism and its service to national exceptionalism. Augustin Berque (1986; 2000) rebuilt it as mesology, the "trajective" co-constitution of societies and their milieux. Miyazaki's worlds map uncannily onto Watsuji's three climates: the monsoon Japan of *Totoro* and *Ponyo*, the meadow Europe of *Kiki* and *Howl*, the desert and acid wastes of *Nausicaä*. Yet they subvert the determinism, since in each climate different persons read the wind differently. Milieu is a relation, not a fate. The bathhouse, a space of *fūzoku* in both senses, is where Chihiro learns to read wind against air.

The classical sources show that the East Asian politics of wind was always double. In the *Analects* (12.19), Confucius tells a ruler that the virtue of the noble person is wind and the virtue of the small person is grass, and that grass must bend when the wind passes over it. The Great Preface to the Mao Odes explains why the first section of the *Classic of Poetry* is called the "Airs of the States": by wind, superiors transform those below, and by wind, those below criticize those above. Wind is therefore both the descending influence of authority, the ancestor of *kūki*, and the ascending, indirect critique of the governed, the ancestor of satire. Miyazaki's *kaze* is the second vector. His winds blow upward and sideways, his grass does not simply bend, and his girls are counter-currents.

11.5 The Wind's Two Faces: Valéry and Benjamin

Paul Valéry's "Le Cimetière marin" (1920), composed above the Mediterranean at Sète, ends: "Le vent se lève!… il faut tenter de vivre!" The wind is rising; we must try to live. The poem's line of perpetual renewal, "La mer, la mer, toujours recommencée," the sea, forever beginning again, could stand as the epigraph to *Ponyo*. Hori Tatsuo rendered the first line in classical Japanese as "Kaze tachinu, iza ikime ya mo." Philologists have long debated the rendering, because the classical construction can also be parsed as a rhetorical question implying the negative: the wind has risen; shall we then live? Surely not. The Japanese line holds Valéry's imperative and its denial in a single breath, and *The Wind Rises* inhabits that suspension.

Walter Benjamin's ninth thesis "On the Concept of History" (1940) describes Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history. Facing the past, he sees a single catastrophe heaping wreckage at his feet. He would like to stay, wake the dead, and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from Paradise has caught his wings so violently that he can no longer close them. It drives him irresistibly into the future, to which his back is turned, and that storm, Benjamin concludes, is what we call progress.

In *The Wind Rises* both winds blow. Valéry's is the wind of life, the rising breeze that commands effort; Benjamin's is the storm of progress that piles wreckage upon wreckage. Jirō hears the first and is carried by the second. The wind that lifts his wings is the wind that will carry the Zeros, and the film's last dream, a field of wreckage and a procession of aircraft that did not come back, is the angel's view.

The film's final word answers both winds. Naoko appears in the dream and tells Jirō to live. According to accounts attributed to Suzuki Toshio, the storyboard originally had her say "come" (*kite*), summoning him to the dead, and the line became "live" (*ikite*). One syllable, an exhalation, separates the invitation to die from the imperative to live. The film was released under the tagline *ikineba*, "we must live," which condenses the conclusion of the *Nausicaä* manga. Here the oeuvre turns on its hinge. The wind that lifts is the wind that kills, and the answer is not to stop breathing but to breathe otherwise: to live in the wind while reading it.

11.6 The Breathing Forest

Emanuele Coccia's *La vie des plantes* (2016) argues that plants made the atmosphere breathable. To live, on this account, is to be immersed in a world composed of others' breath, as a fish is immersed in water; immersion, not position, is the fundamental relation, and the leaf is its paradigm. The film of *Nausicaä* turns, before its final battle, on a discovery of exactly this kind. Beneath the toxic canopy, petrified trees have filtered the poison into pure sand, clean water, and breathable air: the forest is a lung purifying the planet. *Totoro*'s camphor, grown overnight in a dream from a handful of acorns, is a respiratory and cosmic axis. At the end of *Castle in the Sky*, the great tree whose roots embrace the island's crystal core carries the gardens upward while the weapon falls away, a forest aloft with its roots trailing in the sky.

Yet Sheeta's song insists on soil: Laputa fell, she tells Muska, because it severed itself from the ground. Bruno Latour's *Où atterrir?* (2017) argues that politics now turns on a new attractor, the Terrestrial, set against both the Global and the fantasy of escaping the earth. Laputa's final ascent is ambiguous, since the tree-island rises beyond reach, but it rises disarmed, and Pazu and Sheeta land. Every Miyazakian flight lands: Kiki on rooftops, Nausicaä among the Ohmu, Porco on water, Howl's castle in a meadow. Simone Weil's need for roots and Latour's demand to land converge on one instruction: breathe the sky, keep the soil. At the end of *Mononoke* a single *kodama*, a tiny tree-spirit whose head clicks like a wind-chime, appears among the new shoots. The forest is breathing again, on a small scale.

11.7 The Anemotropic Subject

Anemotropism, from *anemos* and *tropos*, names in biology the orientation of an organism by currents of air. The anemotropic subject orients herself by the wind rather than by the room: by the material, shared, contaminated atmosphere rather than the social atmosphere of consensus. She is not closer to nature. She has learned, or kept, a skill of discrimination: sensing which way the air is moving, what it carries, whom it harms, and where it can lift.

The heroines exercise this skill in different registers:

- Nausicaä reads the wind to fly and to know when spores are coming, and she reads the Ohmu's eyes, blue in calm and red in rage, as a sailor reads the sky.
- Chihiro must hold her breath crossing the bridge to the bathhouse, because breath would reveal her to the spirits as human; startled, she gasps and is seen. Breath is the human signature, the one thing the spirit world can detect.
- Kiki undergoes a crisis of inspiration in the literal sense. Ursula tells her the gift is breathed in rather than owned, and Kiki recovers flight on a borrowed street-sweeper's brush when another life is at stake: lift is borrowed.
- Sophie, a maker of hats, the objects the wind most likes to steal, ages and grows young with the breath of her confidence, and walks on air beside Howl.
- San first appears sucking poisoned blood from Moro's bullet wound and spitting it onto the ground. She takes the poison into her mouth to save another and does not pass it on.
- Ponyo breathes water and air, and Himi commands fire, which lives on air.

Honda's *hirahira*, the girl's fluttering ribbon, makes her body a vane, and Cixous's *voler* makes her flight a theft.

The position is open to boys. Mahito's guide is a gray heron, *sagi*, a word that sounds the same in Japanese as *sagi*, fraud: the lying wind. Mahito becomes anemotropic by learning to read deception, first the heron's and finally his own. The late films thus complete the argument of Chapter 6. The anemotropic subject is not a gender but a discipline.

11.8 Kotodama and the Pact of Breath

The *Man'yōshū* calls Japan the land where *kotodama*, the spirit of words, brings fortune. Words are breath shaped by the mouth, and to speak is to exhale force. Miyazaki has described the world of *Spirited Away* as one in which words bind: saying that one wishes to work obliges the employer, and losing one's name is losing oneself (Miyazaki 2014). The bathhouse is ruled by contract, Pateman's instrument of subordination (Chapter 8). Its counter-economy is a pact of breath.

Mauss's gift binds persons through obligation and return. David Graeber's *Debt* (2011) identifies a "baseline communism": the principle of giving according to ability and receiving according to need, operative among intimates and in every emergency. Chihiro's relations with Lin, Kamaji, Zeniba, and No-Face run on it, help asked and given without accounting. Its emblem is the hair tie Zeniba weaves with No-Face, Boh, and the bird, which protects because friends made it. The film's climax is a reciprocal naming. Chihiro remembers the river's name and Haku remembers hers, and two beings breathe each other's names back into existence. This is *conspiratio* in Illich's sense: a community constituted by shared breath.

11.9 Ma as Respiratory Form

Ma, the interval Miyazaki explained by clapping his hands, is the respiratory form of his cinema. The bus stop, the Sea Railway, Porco's siesta on his island, Kiki's afternoons in the bakery, Jirō's long gaze at the sky: in these intervals action stops and the medium appears. Lamarre's lateral planes slide, and the camera does not strike. The films regulate the viewer's breathing and are structured as inhalation and exhalation. At the tunnel that opens *Spirited Away*, the father notices the wind being drawn inward, as though the other world were inhaling the family; at the end the family is exhaled back into an ordinary afternoon.

Cinema, so understood, is a conspiratorial apparatus: an audience in the dark breathing the same air, attuned together to intervals. It is anti-ballistic cinema in Virilio's sense, a vision machine that does not aim. Its formal politics is the production of attention. Attention is the elementary resistance to *kūki*, because it reads what is actually in the air rather than what the room has agreed is there.

11.10 Whose Breath? The Politics of Air

A humanism of breath risks becoming a mysticism of breath, a universalism that forgets that air is unequally distributed. Frantz Fanon's *L'An V de la révolution algérienne* (1959) described the breathing of Algerians under French colonial occupation as observed and occupied: "combat breathing." Achille Mbembe's "The Universal Right to Breathe" (2020), written in the first months of the COVID-19 pandemic, claimed breath as a right prior to all others, against a brutalism that suffocates bodies and the planet alike. "I can't breathe" became a worldwide political cry. Eric Garner said it in 2014 while New York police officer Daniel Pantaleo held him in a chokehold; the city's medical examiner ruled his death a homicide, a grand jury declined to indict Pantaleo, and he was dismissed from the force in 2019. George Floyd said it in 2020 while Minneapolis police officer Derek Chauvin knelt on his neck for more than nine minutes; Chauvin was convicted of his murder in 2021. Christina Sharpe's *In the Wake* (2016) called antiblackness a total climate, "the weather," and understood care as the work of keeping breath in the body. In 2020 the masks of *Nausicaä* became the planet's ordinary dress.

Miyazaki's films know that breath is unequal. The lepers, the poisoned of Minamata, the Dorok peasants under the mold, the trafficked women of Irontown, and the starving children Honjō counts all breathe worse air than others. So do the pelicans of *The Boy and the Heron*, starving in a sea emptied of fish and driven to devour the unborn. A conspiratorial humanism is therefore not a mysticism but a politics of distribution. It asks who may breathe, who must wear the mask, who breathes the factory's exhaust, and whose air is clean because another's is foul. Wynter's critique applies with full force, since the "human" of classical humanism breathed others' air. Miyazaki's own geography, Japan and an imagined Europe with Asia's other peoples and the global South largely absent, marks the limit of his practice; this thesis extends his principles beyond his maps.

11.11 Seven Theses on Conspiratorial Humanism

The position can now be stated as seven theses, each assigned to the domain it governs.

> Thesis I (ontology). The human is a co-breather. The unit of the human is not the individual but the shared breath. To exist is to be immersed in the breath of others, plants, animals, machines, gods, and the dead, and to return one's own.

> Thesis II (politics). The atmosphere is the first commons. Its enclosure is the primal political act, whether by weapon as atmoterror, by industry as pollution, or by consensus as *kūki*. The conspiracy of those who must breathe is the primal political response.

Thesis III (ethics). Contamination is to be metabolized, not eradicated. Purity is the fantasy of those who can afford clean air, or who would design a humanity worthy of it. The ethical act is to take in what is poisoned without exhaling it onto others: Yupa's arm, San's spitting, Mahito's confession.

Thesis IV (subjectivity). The conspiratorial subject is anemotropic. It reads the wind, not the room. Its paradigmatic figure in Miyazaki is the *shōjo*, not by essence but by position, since she stands outside the economies that teach one to read the room. The late films show the position open to anyone.

Thesis V (care). Care is the provision of breathable conditions: clean air, open windows, intervals, names spoken, burdens shared. Care for those who care is the residual function of the sacred in a disenchanted world.

Thesis VI (aesthetics). Form is respiration. An art that breathes, composing intervals and letting the medium appear, trains attention, and attention is the elementary resistance to the atmosphere of consensus.

Thesis VII (technology). Lift is borrowed. Flight is never transcendence but a relation sustained by a medium one does not own. Every flight must land, and the convivial threshold is the point beyond which a machine begins to own the air.

11.12 Objections and Replies

The first objection is over-reading: Miyazaki never formulates such a theory. The constellational method claims structural coherence, not authorial intention. And the density of atmospheric motifs exceeds coincidence: two titles built on wind, an imperative to live as a tagline, a weapon that kills by exhalation, masks, steam, smoke, and a heroine who is literally a worker of wind.

The second objection is mysticism: breath is a romantic trope. The thesis is anchored instead in a materialist atmospherics: Sloterdijk's history of gas warfare, Nixon's slow violence, Japan's history of *kōgai*, and Mbembe's politics of breath.

The third objection is feminist: the anemotropic girl re-essentializes girls as sensitive media. Here, following Honda, anemotropism is a skill and a position, not a nature. The late films transfer it to boys, and the thesis criticizes rather than celebrates the redemptive burden placed on girls.

The fourth objection is nationalist: *kaze* and *kūki* risk a new *nihonjinron* of Japanese atmosphere. But the fū-lexicon is pan-East Asian, and its political theory is classical Chinese; *conspiratio* is Latin and *pneuma* Greek. The theme is transcultural, and Miyazaki's own laurel-forest identity is pointedly anti-national.

The fifth objection is complicity: Miyazaki's love of warplanes compromises the whole. The thesis incorporates complicity rather than denying it. *The Wind Rises* is an autocritique and Mahito's stone a confession, and conspiratorial humanism begins by acknowledging that one has breathed, and helped to foul, the poisoned air of one's own century.

11.13 Coda: The Tunnel Breathes

Spirited Away opens with a tunnel inhaling a family. It closes with the family exhaled into an ordinary afternoon, the car dusted with leaves, the daughter's hair tie catching the light. Whether Chihiro remembers is left uncertain. A humanism of breath promises neither memory nor purity. It promises only that the air is shared, that it must be read, and that what one breathes in, one is answerable for breathing out.

息

CONCLUSION

Ikiro

This dissertation set out to identify the core philosophical commitments of Miyazaki Hayao's work, to trace their originators, to test them against feminist and humanist thought, and to ask whether a single problem generates them. Its answer is that the problem is the atmosphere, and that the position it generates is a conspiratorial humanism.

Findings

Part I showed that Miyazaki's formation took place inside four atmospheres: the bombed air of 1945, the industrial air of his family's aircraft firm, the sickroom air of a tubercular mother, and the poisoned air of high-growth Japan. His decisive reading supplied five convergent propositions: belonging before the nation (Nakao); the primacy of margins (Amino); catastrophe as the ordinary condition of history (Chōmei, through Hotta); the girl who does not run from the monster (Homer and the Heian lady who loved insects); and flight as grace and violence together (Swift, Saint-Exupéry, Westall). Part II reconstructed four tenets. The first is an animism of attention whose theology is adjacency and whose aesthetic is animation as insufflation. The second is an ontology of violence as contagion, which replaces the villain with the curse and sacrifice with restitution. The third is an ethics of labor and convivial tools that locates the threshold at which hand and wing turn against their makers. The fourth is a love of flight that knows itself cursed.

Part III argued that the *shōjo* is a philosophical position rather than an exemplar or a fetish. Care in the films is the provision of breathable conditions, and its gendering is both exposed and reproduced. Miyazaki's ecofeminism is one without essence: it splits the woman–nature equation through Irontown and relocates domination in the contract. Part IV characterized his humanism as misanthropic, relational, and co-fashioned, Watsuji without the nation. It identified the refusal of purity, culminating in the *Nausicaä* manga, as the oeuvre's decisive philosophical act, historically coincident with Japan's dismantling of its eugenic and leprosy laws. Part V articulated conspiratorial humanism in seven theses and defended them against five objections.

Contributions

To Miyazaki studies, the dissertation offers an atmospheric reading. That reading integrates the ecological, national-cultural, and heroine paradigms, places the manga's ending at the center of the oeuvre, and shows that medium, theology, and ethics form a single pneumatology.

To feminist theory, it offers three things: the *shōjo* as a position defined by exteriority to production and reproduction; the anemotropic subject as an alternative to both essentialist and constructivist accounts of feminine sensitivity; and a reading of Irigaray's forgotten air through a popular, non-Western medium.

To the theory of humanism, it proposes a fourth path beside classical humanism's sovereign dignity, anti-humanism's death of man, and posthumanism's dissolution into networks: a humanism whose unit is the shared breath and whose politics is the distribution of air.

To the environmental humanities, it joins Sloterdijk's atmoterror, Yamamoto's *kūki*, and the East Asian philology of wind in a single analytic of atmospheres.

Limits

The study relies on published statements, translations, and the finished works; it undertakes no archival research into production. Ghibli's films are collaborative, made by Takahata Isao, Suzuki Toshio, Hisaishi Joe, Kondō Yoshifumi, Oga Kazuo, Yasuda Michiyo, and hundreds of animators, and every auteurist reading, this one included, simplifies. The corpus remains open, since Miyazaki is still at work. Reception beyond Japan and the Anglophone world is untreated. The geographic limits of Miyazaki's imagination noted in Chapter 11 are also limits of this study's evidence.

Future Research

Four lines of inquiry follow from this study:

- A comparative study of Takahata's *Kaguya-hime no monogatari* (2013), the other great Ghibli film of a girl and impermanence, released in the same year as *The Wind Rises*.
- An inquiry into the "weather maiden" of post-2011 Japanese animation, notably Shinkai Makoto's *Tenki no ko* (2019), whose heroine can stop the rain, as successor to and challenge for the anemotropic girl.
- An ethics of hand-drawn animation in the age of generative image models, extending Chapter 5.
- An institutional history of Studio Ghibli since it became a subsidiary of Nippon Television in 2023, and of the Ghibli Park that opened in 2022, asking what becomes of a conspiratorial art once it is housed, owned, and visited.

Ikiro

The tagline of *Princess Mononoke* was a single word: *Ikiro*, live. It addressed everyone in the film at once, the prince, the wolf-girl, the ironmaster, the lepers, the gods, and the forest, and it addressed the audience as members of the same shared air. In the grammar this dissertation has reconstructed, to live is to breathe with others. It is to take in a world already contaminated, to refuse to pass on its poisons, to read its winds rather than its rooms, to provide breathable conditions for others, and to land. The wind is rising. Miyazaki's films answer, with Valéry, that we must try to live, and they add what Valéry did not: that we cannot do it alone.

APPARATUS

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APPARATUS

Keywords

Miyazaki Hayao · Studio Ghibli · anime studies · animation theory · conspiratorial humanism · pneumatic humanism · *conspiratio* · atmosphere · breath · wind (kaze) · *kūki* · atmoterrorism · anemotropism · animism · Shinto · *kami* · laurel-forest culture (shōyōjurin bunka) · Amino Yoshihiko · *muen* · Hotta Yoshie · *Hōjōki* · impermanence (mujō) · *ma* · *kotodama* · *fūdo* · mesology · Watsuji Tetsurō · *aidagara* · *shōjo* · girlhood studies · ecofeminism · ethics of care · abjection · purity and contamination · misanthropic humanism · posthumanism · critical humanism · anthropological machine · conviviality · Ivan Illich · Simone Weil · Luce Irigaray · Peter Sloterdijk · Donna Haraway · Val Plumwood · Thomas Lamarre · environmental humanities · slow violence · war memory · aviation and technology · *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* · *Princess Mononoke* · *Spirited Away* · *The Wind Rises* · *The Boy and the Heron*